

Prologue – Theoretical Yield

A bullet whizzed through the oil drum a lab coat-wearing man was hiding behind and ripped a thin hole right through his coat, narrowly avoiding his torso; as it did he found a moment to feel grateful that the drum was empty of its usual contents.

This man appeared fairly young, for one with a doctorate at least. His glasses were coated in dust kicked up from an awful, eventful day. His loafers sunk into soft peat, threatening to seep into the shoe. In his right hand he clutched a pistol tightly, and in his left hand he caressed an odd, jagged object in his coat pocket. It was a struggle to stay focused with all the thoughts running through his head.

He strained his eyes shut, beads of sweat running down his face, his grip on the pistol becoming slicker. The scientist had never been in a shootout before, but it didn't take a chemistry expert to figure out that a bunch of discarded junk in a field was not the kind of place you wanted to be surrounded.

He glanced over at the man next to him, teeth gritted but pain otherwise unreadable beneath aviators. His cover of choice was a big sheet of abject scrap metal lodged between a defunct generator and some cinderblocks, and one couldn't help but notice his thick leather jacket had to have been some level of better armor than lab wear. His weapon, a pump-action shotgun, looked a hell of a lot more reliable than the scientist's pistol, and he would demonstrate that from time-to-time by firing a stray shot out over the sheet metal that protected him; more a show of effort than a shot that would actually take down their aggressors.

A motorcycle lied down on its side in the mud near the trapped duo, similarly taking cover and nursing a hole in its oil tank like a wounded deer.

The scientist continued to caress the object in his pocket.

“You could at least try to take a shot, yeah? It’ll buy us some more time if they think they have to be careful about their approach,” the aviator-wearer grunted.

“I’m, ah, saving my shots,” the scientist responded, “are you really sure the fields were the way to go? It’s large, it’s open, and that over there is becoming increasingly concerning,” he pointed off at the distance where great plumes of fire discolored the horizon and scarred the earth.

“Heading toward the city would’ve had us gridlocked as we crossed the plains, and even if we made it there it would’ve risked too many civilian casualties. This was the right call, we just need a solution to get us out of this one little divot. You’re some sort of genius, right? Figure something out!”

“Tentatively,” the bespectacled man spoke uncertainly, “it comes and goes, in a manner of speaking?”

“Why are you speaking in crossword clues?!” the other said, firing another performative blast over cover.

“I’m sorry, I’ve still got some liquor in me, thinking is a bit disorganized right now.”

“Still?!” said the leather jacket man, incredulous behind his archetypal sunglasses. “All the researchers in that facility, and I end up with you,” he muttered under his breath.

The scientist's face turned a greenish pale just as something equally green and heavy made a wet slop into the mud. It was oval, and protected with a shell. A sheen of dull olive green. An egg of death, a pineapple surprise. All the campy colloquialisms you could imagine would suit it adequately. It sat in the mud, the little nascent catastrophe it was, and when noticed by the pair, the always-suave leather jacket man kicked dirt and screamed "Pizdets!", an expletive that went in and out the scientist's ears.

Which was reasonable regardless of what languages the scientist spoke, because the sight of the grenade made him immediately begin hurling violently.

Chapter 1 - Condensate

Measured, steady voice. A stuffy air of showmanship, conditioned to not let in emotion. Filtered slightly by television broadcast. The kind of mildewy voice that puts you to sleep.

“...Following up on Wednesday’s news of an explosion just east of the industrial park that sent tremors through both the city and the city’s populace, the police have promptly released more details to the public. The explosion was centered within an unowned for-lease factory space that is now suspected to have been used as a makeshift drug laboratory. Based on chemical traces found around the perimeter of the building, it’s believed that this was not an ordinary lab incident, but a deliberate act; be it an internal sabotage, or an attack from an unknown third party. We’ve reached out to police chief George Harton for comment, we should be switching over to him now. Right about... now. That is, now. ...Now.”

Gruff voice. Words spoken through half-chuckles. Muggy air of self-confidence. Lossy audio quality due to a tear in the microphone wind muff. And you could tell just by listening to him talk about other people: what a bastard!

“Hey, can ya hear me? ...Uh, OK, just got a thumbs up. Well, this incident is pretty troubling because, uh, historically Windslow has not been very large in the drug trade business. Little crop-ups like this, we usually stamp out pretty fast. A swift response is what we pride ourselves on. But by the looks of things, y’know, ‘sum asshole or ‘nother got to this one before us. Zero casualties. Perpetrator and motivation unknown. We don’t know if it was a cover-up, or a—a rival gang, or, hell, maybe some lone hellion endangering the lives of others with explosives. It’s even possible, though we make no definitive claim as of now,

that this has some connection to a series of vigilante crimes stricken across the Midwest these past few months. Matter of fact, we have an officer from another county, just came down here askin' to look into it, fits the M.O. apparently. Doll hasn't filled out the paperwork yet though, she's no FBI agent. Not much I can let her do here. But uh, anyway, rest assu—"

The channel flicks to a rerun of an exciting football game from the previous season. Beneath the TV, oblivious to it, surrounded by peanut shells and tethered to a shot glass was a bespectacled man with early scars of aging and the earliest progenitor signs of a bald spot.

"Yeah, so, like, the, uh... the carbocation... that's the intermediate, it, um, so, the methyl group; that's, like, uh, the carbon, but it's not part of the main... carbon... um..."

Niam could not keep his head straight. This was in part due to the blinding lights of the bar, in part due to the commercials talking up some expensive new hair product, and in a much larger part due to the ethanol sticking to the glutamate receptors in his brain. The product of a few shots of vodka; roughly 40% ethanol, as opposed to industrial grade 100% ethanol. This distinction would not be very relevant to the majority of people on this Earth, but to a man of materials science like Niam, this distinction was very relevant. Not that he'd ever been caught doing the latter. Yet.

The bar was bright, and between a merging collage of shapes in front of him Niam could more or less make out the perimeter of a woman's face; maybe with brown—no—more of an auburn hair. He couldn't really make out complexities in facial expression right now, but if he could, he would've found an uneasy glare darting between himself and the exit.

To ease the haze in his head, he began tapping on his forehead idly. Maybe the rhythmic thuds would restore some degree of balance, much like using a bubble level. The little bubble going back and forth, indecisively becoming more centered then more skewed with each tap; a delicate art, but an entertaining one. Any second now, it would be perfectly... level...

Niam opened his eyes and realized that where once sat a woman, there now sat air. Really, really condescending air. The absence of a human being glared at him, and so he glared back. Really gave it the eye. Across the room, a few tearing posters of scantily-clad women smiling with impossibly blemish-free faces were the victims of Niam's piercing gaze, but that was too far for his failing vision to bring to him. The brain was half-asleep, so the eyes weren't afraid to slack off. Any second now, this air would back down. Air is terrible at staring contests.

Niam's leg started vibrating violently, like a wasp's nest was in his pocket. For a second he didn't realize that all these nerve signals were happening. When he did, he spent a moment thinking about it loftily. He moved his hand to his chin purposefully as his leg continued pulsing and spasming.

A blood clot? He wondered. He nodded slowly to himself. He'd figured it out. *Yep. Looks like I'm finally going to die!* He smirked and leaned back, ready to let go. *No greater vacation*, he thought.

For a moment he was flying. One very brief moment. A moment unrecognizable by the human mind. Right after, he was falling, being consumed by the Earth's massive gravitational exertion. Bar stools didn't typically have backs.

He collided with the concrete floor, and felt some strange tingling that would likely register as some pretty nasty spinal pain once his alcohol-impaired brain—OOOOUUUGH! There it was! He suppressed a yelp. Something clattered next to him. Something vibrating furiously like an engine placed in front of the cockpit of an evil machine hellbent on ending everything good about lounging at the bar. In spite of the awful invisible pins shooting through his muscles, he craned his neck to look at the source of the vibrations with a furrowed brow.

It looked kind of flat, and just a little smaller than his hand. And most curiously, when he looked at it, it fired horrible, ominous, omnipotent psychic pain into his sympathetic nervous system with the precision of a scalpel. He could practically see the shadowy vignette circling around it; or, maybe that was his vision giving out under the influence of spirits. And no, not the malevolent ghastly kind.

Apprehensively, inching his hand across the floor, past peanut shells and oddly shaped stains, his drunken hand worked toward the device. Once it was in his grasp, it felt familiarly weighty. And it was angry at him. Very angry at him. He glared at it trying to decipher the hieroglyphs on its face, but they kept shifting. He inched closer to it, before ultimately welling the energy to sit up. Maybe now would be a good time to rub the eyes, see if any of that dreariness would buff out.

It did. Well, sort of. It did *enough*. Enough to read what he now more properly recognized to be his phone screen. It read: "LUNCH BREAK OVER – 12:55 PM". Hmm. Something from some sort of past life of his did seem familiar about this. Some sort of pulsing urgency that started as a whimper but grew to a yell with each pump of blood into

his brain. This ordinarily might've been worrying, but thankfully a flaunty dose of rebellion arrived on scene and began taking control of the situation.

He climbed to his feet and brushed off the peanut dust, becoming more aware of how dry his mouth was. He pinched the bridge of his nose, assessing that he was not plastered—just a little painted. He had reason to suspect there may be a strange machine called a car somewhere in the labyrinthine lot outside, and that he had to find this machine. And that the sharp instruments in his other pocket he landed on when he fell off his chair may be related as well.

With a few pieces of a puzzle of purpose, he resolved to stumble past the languid midday bargoers and towards the exit. If he still had to pay, he had forgotten, and nobody cared enough to catch him as he pushed out the glass doors into the early Winter.

Snow had begun to mound in small colonies in shady corners, and forming their protest blockades in parking spots. Niam paid little attention to the snow, for he was busier trying to remember which of these vehicles were his; a task that was made more difficult by the harsh wind in his ear and his residual drunkenness. Somewhere in the distance, a car alarm went off, mounting on the noisy distractions. The parking lot was an expanse of chilly matrices, every occupied spot housing a number of variables to sift through.

This was too much for his foggy head to swim through. *Where was a good place to start? Shape? Ehh... Make? Definitely not... what about color? Color might be good.* He was sure it was green. Greenish. Some interpretation of green. Over a small trickle of motor oil bleeding in with the black ice, Niam followed a concrete path, scanning the spanning blocks of vehicles for the color of pine. Passing under a dead tree floating overhead like a spiked

cloud of bad thought, his feet guided him towards the fifth row of cars; one that was notable for the multiple soggy receipts stewing in some pooling drain water nearby.

This must be the row, he thought to himself as he was already tracing over somewhat familiar pavement. With each step he grew more sure that he was going the right way, but a ball of stress also started building up in his stomach. The more sure he was that he was growing closer to his car, so too did the car alarm he was hearing grow louder. Without really knowing how he knew, he started to slow down near a 1972 Sedan flashing lights rhythmically and screeching hellfire. Pine green. And there was someone there—not the car's owner. Somehow he knew this. Having successfully guided Niam back to his car, his feet took the opportunity to join the rest of the body in drunken stupor and promptly went numb.

Niam was watching someone rifle through his car through a broken window. He rubbed his eyes, wondering if the burglar wouldn't just vanish in the same haze that everything seemed to in his mind right about now.

"Hey, um... hey... hey asshole!" he said, trying to piece together how to be confrontational from his tired mind. The burglar turned around. Underneath a street-dirtied bush of peppered hair, it was a sort of picturesquely filthy woman in well-worn flannel. In her hand she was holding a disorganized stack of paper. Upon seeing Niam, she furrowed her brow and clenched her fists, further damaging the uncared for slips of scrap paper. She trembled as she raised her pointer finger.

"You! You the owner of this car, uh?" She spoke with an unpracticed lack of rhythm, more intent on yelling loud enough to overtake the alarm than she was on communicating

any real sentiment. Niam wasn't paying a great deal of attention anyway, trying to figure out a good follow-up to his hostile opening.

"Me—? Uh— yeah, yeah, I think so... um—" but he was cut off by the rising temper of the burglar.

"THEN YA OUGHTA BE ASHAMED! THERE'S NOTHIN' IN HERE! JUST PAPER, PAPER, ALL PAPER! YOU AN ARTIST?!" she shouted, shoving one of the papers into Niam's face. He straightened his glasses and tried to read it as it shook about in front of him. It was a couple hexagons, some lines, some letters, and an arrow between them. He searched his memory.

"No—what? I... that appears to be the... chlorination of cyclohexane, right? I guess I was messing around with it at some point. Not sure why. Not very useful for much besides uh, as an intermediate, I guess..." and as he spoke, he nearly forgot that his car had been broken into, instead distracted by the familiar patterns and shapes. Finally, the woman's temper blew over and she threw her arms up into the air, scattering the papers she was holding into the sky, where the wind promptly seized its opportunity to grab them and run off. "BAH! WASTE MY TIME ON THE CAR OF SOME ARTS AND CRAFTS MAN! SHITTER!"

Niam felt like he was supposed to be mad, but it was only four or five pages—and as he watched them float away up into a gray sky it almost felt like some unseen clutter in his mind was being whisked out the window. By the time he looked back down, the grouchy crook had already angrily stalked off, visible some 15 meters or so in the distance kicking an empty bottle and keying someone's SUV. Niam's hand slid idly into his pocket and grabbed for the keyring inside. He unlocked his car as he was trying to remember how to unlock it. This whole experience was becoming very played out, and he cursed himself

silently for day drinking again while trying to remember what he was day drinking to escape from.

The alarm stopped after he unlocked the door, which was a great relief to his pounding headache. Bitter cold sunlight faded in through the tinted windows, and inside Niam saw dunes of white wood pulp surrounding valleys of pencil-marked parchment: a landscape made up entirely of haphazardly composed notes. Shapes and hasty calculations made up the finer minutia of this calligraphy cartography. His vision shook a little as he tried harder to peer through the window, but his own shadow only made it tougher to see in.

He sighed and sunk down into the driver's seat, shutting the door as he entered. The chemical reaction equation infestation continued its perforation even in the front, with two sizable clusters of paper on the passenger seat, and even a stray bit of equilibria down by the driver's pedal. It resembled a bunch of old newspapers scattered in an alley for a stray dog to sleep on; just as mud-crusts and sundried as well.

Key in ignition. Engine roaring and heating up. Radio playing prog rock. Hands on the steering wheel. Everything in its proper place. Except; one thing missing. A destination. Son of a bitch. Niam turned down the prog rock just as the emotional ambient cello kicked in to try to leave some room to think. Directions were not a strong suit of his, and no less so when a bit tipsy, and no less so when experiencing a strange fugue state.

Muscle memory alone told him to put the car in reverse to pull out of the spot. *This is going to be a hell of a trip*, he thought. *Let's see how far muscle memory can take me*. He felt

something clench in the pit of his stomach. Wherever he was heading, it was somewhere bad. He urged the residing alcohol in his system to numb just a little bit more.

Chapter 2 - Recrystallization

Though it was difficult to tell from the inside out, Niam couldn't shake the feeling that this was not how the average buzz felt. He wasn't sure where he sat between déjà vu and jamais vu as half-familiar landmarks glazed past his eyes. His head felt like a soup of thought and memory from which he could only draw tiny teaspoons of at a time. The full contents of his brain were not available to access all at once, and his mind raced for reasons: maybe some sort of neural damage, maybe he really had gone just a little too far this time and the alcohol had went and melted something important inside. Or maybe it was some sort of protection mechanism, a praetorian shield wall keeping in all the nastiest bits of being conscious. He was finding as he picked out pieces of the world, such as how he felt about large cars that skipped lanes around him or the mannequins in store windows, that it was all spiked with little hints of malcontent. It all made him...

SKRRRRRRRRRRRRRTCHT! He slammed on the brakes at the last second, noticing the stop sign late. The pedestrian in front of his hood froze up in fear, the vehicle coming close enough you could touch the hood. It was some leather jacket wearing sleazebag. Niam accidentally made eye contact with them through their aviators before narrowing his eyes and waving them along. They flipped him off in return. Even Niam's hazy memory begrudgingly remembered what this gesture meant. A small amount of anger flared up, bubbling up into and dissolving within the numb sea of apathy clouding his mind. It wasn't important and so he suppressed it; he knew he was nearly at his destination.

A short time later, he took a right and turned out of suburbia and onto a road cutting through an open dry field of wild oats that spent their days fraternizing with the wind. Grey and white blocky buildings stood huddled off in the distance, isolated in their clique. Niam figured now that he was headed for the industrial park, evident from the tendril-like network of roads leading in and out of the cluster of cubic architecture. Defaced speed limit signs, flashy billboards, and trash-filled ditches off the side of the road are becoming more and more familiar now. Driving past the sign for the first office building brought to mind the entering of a labyrinth, one built of straight-edged floors with cubicle walls, and with a threat more existential than a minotaur. Or at least, these were thoughts that occurred to Niam from somewhere in the storage shelves of his mind. They were recycled musings.

From here, it was three straights, a right, a left, and then another right. He wasn't exactly sure how much time had left now, and to be frank he didn't pay attention to how much time he had to begin with so he wasn't sure why he was keeping track now. He wasn't sure how long he had been doing each of these habits that were flowing through him like old blood, but he knew he was already sick of them.

Straight, straight, straight, right, left. Just before the final right turn, a blocky modern sign proclaimed *Windslow Chemical Research Laboratory* in a neat serif font. The sight of the name was an overdue library book to his mind. Something that had slipped it and now he was landing on his back. He had been helping discover something big. Something that was still more mentally taxing than his mental savings could mentally afford. But it had thumped from under the floorboard and made its presence known. It was only a matter of time before it would spurt up like a geyser. He took the last turn slowly and was now

inching towards a fenced-off building near the edge of the industrial park. It was protected by a guard booth and gate.

As if anyone would want to break in here... he thought to himself sardonically. He rolled up very slowly to the guard booth and rolled down his window. An older man with a greying widow's peak sat inside the booth, reading from a newspaper with tiny splotches of visible water damage. It was held up tall in front of him like the Berlin Wall, with the date blocking his face: November 27th, 2024. Niam twiddled his thumbs over the steering wheel, waiting to get noticed.

The guard leaned back, cracked the newspaper, and sighed hard enough that it ruffled the paper slightly. It was apparent that he was deliberately enjoying this time he could laud over Niam. This too felt familiar. He reached for the volume knob on his radio and flashed it up a few times to try to get the guard's attention.

And if there was ever a place for those who are alone,

It would BE SOMEWHERE THAT WE'VE NEver known!

If there was ever refuge, ever some KIND OF HOME,

EVER A PLace where the groundwater could flow

With all the enthusiasm of a wallowing hippopotamus, the newspaper wall came down. At last, contact with the inside. The guard creased up his face a little and crept his finger towards a button connected to a speaker.

“State your purpose or present your ID. Please,” his speech was slow, and pre-steeped in the poisoned well of annoyance. In Niam’s mind he had yet to do anything flagrantly rude, so some confusion stirred. Did he really need his ID? He worked here, after all, and chemical research labs were not establishments famous for their hundreds of workers.

“But I’m one of the sixteen people who work here. You know my face, right?”

The guard chuckled grimly. “Oh, I know your face alright, Dr. Wrecker. ID. Now.”

Niam recoiled slightly in response. *Doctor? Am I really? Who in their right mind would give me a doctorate?*

“C’mon, I—really...?”

“If we’re so familiar with one another, Wrecker, you should have no trouble remembering my name.”

Niam turned and looked straight ahead at the gate barring him entry, though in truth he was staring right through it. The song that was playing had just ended, and a cloying silence filled the car.

“ID, Dr. Wrecker.”

There was that title again. It reeked of responsibility. *Can't I be a lab assistant? Or a janitor?* He thought to himself.

Niam sighed and began vetting his pockets for what he knew had to be some kind of rectangle, because on that rectangle he knew there would be a smaller rectangle with a picture of his face on it, laminated next to his name in a brash all-caps font. Both sweater pockets turned out a failure. Left pocket, right pocket, back pockets; none were turning up with his ID. He went to glance sheepishly at the security guard, but he was already deeply entrenched in his newspaper once more.

Out of desperation more than any strain of logic, he began feeling around on the floor of the backseat until he grasped at some sad washed-up cloth scrap. Bringing it in front of him, it was a crumpled white ball with some odd stains. He unfolded it apprehensively until it began to resemble a garment that someone could feasibly wear. A little long, with buttons and coat pouches. He held it out in front of him like it was something he'd pulled out of a drainage pipe, and a little card slipped out of one of the pockets and landed amongst the floor equations. He loftily tossed the lab coat into the passenger seat and reached down to grab the card.

NIAM WRECKER – AGE: 35 – SEX: M – JOB: RESEARCH CHEMIST. In his ID photo, Niam is smiling, but nervously. First day jitters still visible. The picture radiated a genuine excitement. The man in this photo was still Niam, but it was no mirror. He suddenly felt a little nauseous; must've been the vodka coming back up. Quickly as not to linger on the card any longer, he thrust it face out towards the guard.

The guard was just now bringing the newspaper wall back down, having correctly guessed the time it would take Niam to play scavenger hunt. Without saying a word, he sniffed stiffly and opened the gate. Niam minimized eye contact and drove inside with such abated desperation that the vehicle jerked back, and then forward after an over corrective brake.

Niam was now cornered in by metal fences, concrete walls, and the familiar eye of camera feeds. Left was visitor parking, right was for depot. He had to go all the way around through the visitor parking to reach employee parking. That much was easy, for it was completely deserted. The difficulty came after he pulled through a little archway with a restricted access sign.

To say it was cramped would be an understatement. The backs of cars stuck out like marmots—only a couple tons heavier and with potentially litigious owners who hated vehicle damage. He inched through the parking lot little by little, making small and precise movements like he was trying to tune a machine just so. In his mind, he pictured a vial inside a ^1H NMR (Hydrogen Nuclear Magnetic Resonance) machine, being rotated just so between two magnets by arms.

Still inebriated as he was, however, he did not even come close to scraping the efficiency of a machine, and instead came much closer to scraping the rear of a white SUV. There was a spot for him here, this he knew, he just had to look for the empty space.

There at the end, on the right and hidden by a pick-up truck, was a space about seven eighths the size of a regular one. He fought his way in, going forward, reversing, forward, reversing, forward, reversing; until he was in. He breathed a sigh of relief and

kneaded his forehead to try to get some of the pain out. Two surly-looking guys stood in a shady corner next to a ladder nearby and took a moment to point at Niam, probably laughing it up, but Niam hardly noticed.

The mission was a success. Autopilot had taken him this far. Now it was time for Niam to sift through the haze and dig down for the real questions.

What the hell am I doing here?

There were clues to this puzzle, and they littered the floor and seats of his car. The problem was a matter of dating. He picked up a sleeve of paper off the passenger seat and skimmed it. Complex organometallic reactions to create energy-storing molecules. Dr. N. Wrecker, co-signed Dr. S. Been. April 13th, 2022. Too old. Moreover, someone had taken a pen and scribbled “IRRELEVANT - PROJECT TERMINATED” in large red letters over the front.

He searched for another. A set of data ripped from a larger report, with visual aids and diagrams to help explain it. It looked like a bunch of balls: maybe billiards, or marbles. Or particle physics. Niam adjusted his glasses, hoping it would aid his blurry vision at all. These were collider results. They followed a trend. Higher collision rates, more coolant flow, increased power draw. This paper had the authoritative aura of importance. It was a dry read to sift through, but emanated an arrogant self-confidence in its importance, with all its rigid lines and compact cells.

Even still, the finish line was unmapped. What was this for? Supercollisions were for making things. New things, things that didn't want to exist. Things that were so energetically unfavorable, so unstable, they otherwise would never exist. These things

didn't stick around for long, it was not an industrial production process. It was for research. We hope to learn things from these brief iotas of impossibility. Typically, it was one of three things that we are hoping to discover. A new quark, or qualities about them. A new compound that exists for less than a blink. Or a new element, with more protons, neutrons, and electrons than should ever be forced into one place. And when too many things are stuck together, they explode apart.

Always with the new, Niam thought. Everything new seems great on paper until you have to go and do it. He tossed the paper aside, reached for his pitiful lab coat, and stepped out of the car through the tiny crack the door could be opened. He still wasn't sure what he was going in this lab to do, but he knew that he couldn't waste any more time. There was some sort of pressure building in the building, and the longer he waited to go in there, the more explosive it would be when uncorked.

A **bird** had built a nest inside a satellite dish on top of the building, and from its perch it looked down at the man in white apprehensively heading towards the discreetly marked employee entrance. The bird didn't like all the vibrating from below, coming from the big metallic rectangle, or the fire-hearted beasts that patrolled back on forth on the blackened, barren roads.

Despite this, it chose the satellite dish as its own because its own birdsong was caught in the dish like a bowl of water, and then was sloshed around its conical shape and back at itself. It sounded like a bird of the same feather. It felt like company. It didn't know it was the only finch in miles. The bird quivered imperceptibly, its heart beating faster than any person's, many calculated flight trajectories happening all around it in its head,

invisible but always present like a sense of balance. The man wearing white entered the building, thankfully not a threat today. It checked on its eggs one last time before flying off, over the massive circular snake trailing outside the industrial park and looping back into itself. The bird had no way of knowing or even beginning to fathom that a nest like this in a place like this could be interfering with. A bird does not know what a sinusoidal wave is. Even still, by way of the world ignorance was no cause for exception. The nest likely would not remain in this dish for long. At best, relocated. At worst, destroyed.

The halls of the lab sounded harrowingly quiet save for the sound of heavy ventilation reverberating throughout the halls, akin to air being suctioned out of an airlock. To the left and right, countless doors with windows leading to self-contained worlds of study. There could only be around four or five in the building, but the complexity of each was enough that it would individually take people centuries per lab to retroactively figure out the purpose of each room and instrument following an apocalypse. It smelled sterile.

It's uncanny how unfamiliar something you've seen every day can look. Sometimes like you're seeing it for the first time, and other times it's because it feels as if something imperceivable has changed. Whichever Niam felt now he was not paying enough attention to know.

In the middle of the hall marked by signs and arrows pointing up was a medium-sized staircase leading up to another, seemingly larger side of the building. Niam climbed the staircase, dragging his feet, lolling his head. One would think that driving would be one of the harder things to do inebriated, but as Niam grew closer and closer to his destination he felt a greater and greater effect of a magnet-like psychic repulsion.

The top of the staircase. Two heavy push-bar lever doors. Niam hit them with the least enthused shoulder tackle to ever disgrace the town; he was now inside. He entered a room with plenty of desks and computerized equipment. Through angled windows looking down, he saw a serpentine tube of alloy, held in place by intersecting metallic scaffolding.

To Niam's right, a heavy door marked with a light and a placard advising mandatory safety protocols. Helmets and vests hung from an adjacent rack.

To Niam's left, a long ramp descended into more laboratory. From below, he heard the hushed whispers of terse discourse. He could hardly hear them over the heavy hum of the room's power draw echoing from the walls; chasing after the conversations, he followed the noises while rubbing his eyes.

The ramp was wide, long, and minimally steep. Designed for carts containing critical payloads or racks of data could easily be pushed to and from. This area was more study than lab, with illustrated diagrams and tables on the wall, and a few complex theoretical models. Off to the right through further ramp redundancy led to the sector of the lab intended for monitoring and controlling the particle accelerator, evident from the bunches of wires snaking towards it. This was from whence the voices steamed up into the rest of the lab.

Fluorescent lights buzzed overhead; the sound choked up not in the ventilation of the rooms before, but by the busy hum and flickering of twenty-something computer monitors and their accompanying towers. A few figures in lab coats were dissertating with some dress shirt clad tech nerds very physically, waving their hands around and pointing at a cream-colored control console, each other, and then back at the console.

Niam's hands went to his coat pockets. He wasn't sure precisely why, but he suddenly took on the demeanor of a child tardy to class. It felt as if he were walking into a veritable mushroom cloud of dissent that would combust as soon as he entered, a phosphorus-tipped match waiting for the perfect surface to strike.

The heel of his dress shoe was the match, the epoxy-coated floor was the matchbox surface: and baby? It struck. Everyone in the room: some odd two to four chemists, eight technicians, and maybe a nuclear physicist stared him down with barely concealed exasperation. No one seemed surprised, but perhaps more disappointed. Aggrieved.

Niam went to straighten his tie in an effort to salvage a scrap of professionalism, but found that he was not in fact wearing one. Dreadfully embarrassing. He silently hoped the spiderweb of damaged nerve vessels on his face hid some of that embarrassment.

The most visibly upset of the lab coat clad clamored past the crowd, clinging to a clipboard. She was maroon in soul and temperament—whatever that meant—and was a good couple decades senior to Niam.

"Some detestable yet expected state you saunter in here as, Wrecker," she said, thrusting a pen at him in gesture. "While you were out drinking, we were having a crisis."

"...What kind of crisis?" Niam asked sheepishly, to the bemused look of several professionals who had already spent a considerable amount of time exploring every possibility of whatever this problem was, and who were not looking too ecstatic to retrace over very tread ground.

“A mass crisis. An unexpected mass crisis. As in, a foreign object in the collider. Multiple, all similar.”

Niam blinked like a photocopier scans its input. “Well that’s... stupid. Yeah, that’s not supposed to happen. We’re talking about a machine that deals exclusively in the smallest particulates of reality and I’m supposed to believe some massive objects are just lying around in there? What are they, a raccoon? An opossum?” Niam lashed out in response to the thick emotional energy of the room. “There’s no chance it’s been this hard to identify.”

“Well isn’t that convenient for you to say, man-who’s-been-absent-since-noon,” the maroon woman retorted. Niam blinked. She continued, “what do you even think we’re doing here?! We are smashing the heaviest elements against the heaviest elements at speeds incomprehensible to the mind for moments of time slimmer than the amount of time you spend sober! Foreign objects in the collider means we could have FOUND something,” she explained tersely.

Niam felt this didn’t quite add up, and his brain was just now starting to catch up a little to the point where he felt he could put his finger on it properly.

“...We deal with unstable, radioactive radicals and massive radii, the things we make don’t last for more than a few seconds at most. Typically less.”

“I’m not an idiot, Wrecker. I know! We all have PhDs in this field! That’s why when everyone is crowded around arguing over it, you can assume something pretty god damn exceptional and DIFFICULT to identify has happened!”

Scolded like a child, Niam backed up slightly, where he felt a nudge on his arm and looked to his right to find a dishonest looking technician pouting his lips and nodding knowingly.

“Don’t worry. I think it’s possums too,” he said with unfounded confidence. Niam pretended to smile. The maroon woman, who Niam knew he knew and whose name he knew he should know, exasperatedly retreated back into the crowd to grab a data reading from a nearby printer.

“Someone get Wrecker up to date. I can’t be in charge of that,” she delegated in a far more controlled manner than she had been speaking to Niam.

A somewhat meeker woman, more of a violet mind, crept out of the crowd. She carried a stack of printed out data sheets, proffered them to Niam rigidly, then turned and stepped away without saying a word.

Niam eyed the sheets he was handed, similar to the one he’d found in his car only with fresher ink. And bigger numbers. Weird, weird numbers. He flipped through the pages.

A particle heat map. Hm. Odd. Why is there a large lump in the middle here? Not perfectly round, a bit jagged. But uniform. Crystalline, really.

“Looks like there’s a, um, ah, foreign objects in the—you know.”

He knew he was jostling a wasp nest by stating the obvious, but didn’t manage to catch himself until he had already started speaking. The response was a sizzling silence and a few glares. Computers whirled and the white noise pulled at the bottom stretches of

Niam's brain. Were he a free man with no responsibilities here, he would gladly go and pass out somewhere. Maybe in a sunny field.

"It's just unprecedented," someone said, "and I know it's dangerous to get your hopes up, but I think it could be huge. This could be a... a *thing*."

"Or it could be a readout error from some tediously small imperfections or general wear on the machine," someone else added matter of factly.

Niam's head spun under the fluorescent lights as if he was viewing his coworkers arguing from up above, far away, and getting further. He saw himself, looking dazed as ever. He saw the computer lab as little blocks. More and more it all resembled a speck. The lurking hunch that had been stalking him all the way from the bar was now tingling down his spine like a running stream. His parched throat ached not for water, but for another drink. Where an arid desert lacks moisture, this arid lab lacks joy. He watched as the cluster of professionals would swap between one another, breaking off into smaller debates, forming groups of differential sizes like water droplets running down the side of a shower. He knew they were talking, as people did, but from up here it was noise all the same as the computer fans and electrical buzz.

"Wrecker. Wrecker!" Niam was pulled from his trance through way of snapping fingers in his face. Ms. Maroon was in front of him. "Focus. Listen. We're going into the tunnel to follow the collider to see if anything is outwardly wrong with it," she paused to make sure what she was saying was registering, "*you're* going to stay here with the printout and the programmers, you're going to sober up, and you're going to be ready to talk about this when we're back."

She then stepped past him, as did the rest of the chemists, physicists, and technicians, before all disappearing up the ramp and around the corner. Hollowly, Niam looked down at the stapled papers in his hand and tapped them lightly against his palm. He fingered through the report a little further; the white of the paper bounced the light above back into his eyes in a painful manner.

The energy fluctuations were bizarre. A low rumble, even when the usual background noise was accounted for, as well as consistent peaks that reached numbers which rang no bells in Niam's mind. But the most odd part about it was a tiny box detailing the average speed of the measured nuclei. Someone had assertively underlined it with an off-black pen. This reading was unusually slow. Very slow, in fact. Almost half of what I'd think to expect.

Niam wanted to point it out, but had already been scolded already for pointing out the obvious. If someone had underlined it with pen, it was likely already known to the room.

The origin of consistent outliers are typically that of a systemic error. A consistent flaw in readings means one of the sensors could be on the fritz, something that could alter the data at the same points, in the same way. And while it was true that there was consistency to these readings based on the peaks, the period between the peaks followed no clear pattern. That was odd. It was odd in a particular, familiar, head-splitting kind of way. The way that really made one yearn for a—

"I'm certain everything's fine with the program, readout, calculations, whatever. Back-end's fine, we don't even *have* a front-end. This isn't on us, not our prerogative at all. I

hid beers in the mini-fridge in the break room. You guys wanna go piss about?" a scrawny programmer asked the others. Niam made eye contact with him. They stared on at one another for an uncomfortably long time. "And, uh, you're free to join us too if you want, doctor," the programmer finally added.

Trepidation.

"No, I probably shouldn't. Already had a shot or two today. Been feeling kind of weird."

Chapter 3 - Initiation

In the break room, small beer cans scattering like rats, shitty rock pumping out of a stereo, and cup ramen rotating in the microwave, Niam stood asking some of the technicians who had invited him (they had names, but he was inept at remembering such things) about their weekend plans. It was Friday after all, a nearby calendar said so. That meant it was time to think about weekend plans. Calendars didn't tend to lie. He was in a smaller group of four, conversations having split off throughout the party. The bulkiest of the programmers furrowed his brow.

"Well, hopefully our lead tech can convince Dr. Been that we have nothing to do with this blockage mess and we can actually *have* our weekend plans. *We* have a bowling tournament to play in," he gestured at the other tech men, who nodded and murmured agreement.

"Can't miss our bowling tournament. Very exclusive," one added.

"Must be tough for you though, doctor. You're in a lot of hot water, always late as you are. Boss lady is pissed. 'Where's Wrecker?! Where's that asshole?! This is *his* fucking research!' and all that. Profanities being thrown around. It was a whole thing. You were a pretty big reason that room was so tense I figure; if this blockage turns out to be a big deal you can kiss your weekend goodbye."

Niam felt nervous sweat on his back. It had already been creeping there insidiously for minutes, but he only now noticed it as his shirt began to cling to his back.

“Honestly,” the quietest of the technicians finally spoke, “I’m surprised you’re here right now. I’ve never seen someone with a doctorate be such a delinquent. Making us all look good by comparison, y’know.”

“But— wait— hold on, you’re the ones who invited me!” Niam tried to state this matter-of-factly, but he couldn’t suppress his defensiveness.

“We just spent twenty minutes having to hear about how you would rather, I quote the Boss Lady, ‘prioritize a drop of ethanol over your entire career’. You hear stuff like that, and that’s the kind of guy you’d want to shoot the shit with. So we offered, you accepted! That’s some ‘I don’t give a fuck’ energy like I’ve never seen,” the scrawny programmer said, gesturing his beer can towards Niam in a lazy toast. “That’s pretty cool.”

Niam smiled weakly and gestured a vague toast back. *Cool*. Cool’s good, right? It’s cool to avoid your job? He wanted to be cool. Even still, he felt the consequences on the horizon, rising like the sun after he’d been out all night. And the clouds were maroon. And maybe it was gonna rain a few hours after that. And maybe a satellite would crash right on top of him. He shook his head to clear it.

“To be honest,” he started unexpectedly, “I’m not even really sure what I’m doing here. Not here, the break room; but here, this lab. Hell, maybe even here in this world. I’ve been feeling really strange since I went to the bar today. I don’t think it’s a new feeling, but it’s louder now than ever. Like I’m being watched. Like I just woke up inbetween two dreams in the middle of the night, and I can process it for a split second. But only through murky, y’know, half-logics.”

The techs shared sudden compulsory glances. Whatever this was, this was *not* cool. It was troubling, and confusing.

“Buddy, you’re a *doctor*. You spent years getting a *degree* specifically to be here. Not to mention you’re kind of vital to this research, aren’t you? We’re making these super heavy element things because *you* were the one who thought they could be a big breakthrough.”

“I thought that?” Niam thought to the paper detritus turning his car into a written-word collage piece. Clearly this work was something once important to him. *So... why does it feel so distant now?* Something began creeping up his spine slowly, but he was sure if he swatted at it there’d be nothing there at all. Thankfully, he had quick access to what he found to be the best way to smoke down thoughts like this. He grabbed another beer. “Forget I said anything. Less talking, more drinking,” he rushed to raise his drink. The programmers were on board with this notion at least.

Opening his eyes, Niam saw the room like it was out of a cartoon. Trashed beyond belief, covered in litter, devoid of people, even the lights were off. Cans on the table, cans on the floor, a case that formerly held beer crushed, and even a table pushed onto its back like an odd tortoise. Niam half-expected to see the comical archetypal drunk partygoer hazily slumbering past their welcome, before realizing that this was, in fact, who he was in this case.

This is ridiculous, he chastised himself, when does shit like this ever happen to real people?!

He had closed his eyes for one second. Truly, one second. A long blink, really. And now he was here. He sat up, but much too quickly. It made him nauseous. A familiar kind of nausea he often felt at parties.

Niam always hated the feel of deserted parties. For one, they were just downright depressing, weren't they? And for two, they were a lot of work to clean up. It was time to go.

At this point, the feeling that he should be doing something related to his job was getting loud enough to be annoying. It wasn't overwhelming yet, but it was raising his voice.

Just as he was preparing to leave the room, however, something caught his eye, under a lopsided beer can dripping out its innards at the pace of a dead man. It was a stapled stack of papers, the very same stapled stack of papers the maroon woman had handed to him. Someone had been using it as a beer coaster.

He leapt to his feet, or kind of stumbled to them anyway, and went to brush the can off those extremely important papers. Now the papers were in his hands. Great. Now he was going to try to read it again. FANTASTIC.

Something must have caught his subconscious's eye earlier, and it was trying ever-so-desperately to bring this detail to the front; but the follow-up dose of beer he had just downed was delaying that connection considerably. Even still, his tolerance to alcohol was greater than his incident in the bar would lead one to believe, and now that the indefinable confusion was starting to take more concrete form, he could also form more concrete ideas.

"A never-before-synthesized element containing 140 protons could be produced if this collision goes as planned," he read the abstract aloud, "if we are lucky enough to capture retroactive traces of it, we plan to confirm its existence.

Though, as this element would surpass theorized limits on how many protons an element can contain without inner electrons exceeding the speed of light (calculated and suspected to be 137 protons), this element could exhibit unprecedented effects if it proves synthesizable at all.”

Well, that seems important, he thought.

Niam suspected his fellow chemists were aware of this as well—it is, after all, the primary purpose of the experiment. It quickly entered his recollection now why this blockage was the cause of such a din.

‘Unprecedented effects’. It was intentionally vague because it’s rather difficult to theorize accurately about the unknowable. But Wrecker knew what they were hoping for. It was the same cement shoes he had felt weighing him down all day: stability.

Stability, the core tenet of anything that has some considerable impact in the world. If it’s short-lived, it’s useless. Or at least this is a popular bias of contemporary society. For example, things like carbocations—that is, molecules with a carbon containing a positive charge—are so reactive they are gone in a moment. And yet, they are still the intermediate step of that reaction. Logic dictates they must exist, and indeed there are other ways to confirm their existence. But as a rule of thumb, humans prefer things that stick around, because those are things you can rub your hands on and get to work with.

The stability of something as heavy as an element with 140 protons, however, is ridiculous. It shouldn’t even exist, let alone prove to have stability. The bigger the nucleus, the faster electrons must orbit around it, and with a size that dense the electron would simply exceed the speed of anything ever before witnessed. So fast would these electrons

be, that they'd exceed the speed of light. And If something exceeds the speed of light, well, that raises a couple problems, right?

But what if it didn't exceed the speed of light at all? What if instead it broke through some theoretical wall and emerged in a new form? An inversion, if you will, a voice in Niam's head proffered. The speaker's words sounded so rehearsed that it could've been a quoted excerpt taken directly from someone's notes, and in fact he recognized the words after a moment. They were his. At some point, at some time.

A conference, maybe. Was he the kind of guy to do conferences? Hard to imagine. Even still, now that the thought occurred to him he could practically see the blinding lights from where he stood in his memory, up on a stage.

Niam crept out of the break room and started pacing around the halls as he chased down more memory voices.

My co-researcher's claims might sound starry-eyed and naïve, but his reasoning is not entirely unfounded, another familiar voice proceeded over his own, *as his thesis paper was a step towards proving this very idea.*

Then, a dead end ensued. Niam had no memory of his thesis paper. Niam wasn't even sure which university he attended. With an incomplete mental portfolio he'd now be forced to face his boss, because he knew he had to be back in the lab ready to discuss those findings by now he could well even be late by this point, as he had no clue how long he had been passed out. Based on hunch alone he wasn't even convinced it was alcohol consumption that had knocked him out, not that anything else had a plausible case.

He rushed back into the lab just in time to find it empty, wipe his brow in relief, and then hear the screech of a heavy door open and shut as the hushed clamoring of techs and chemists returning to the room.

“No signs of exterior damage, so we’re going to have to wait a few days for the techs to disassemble the collider and look inside,” the maroon woman whom he had inferred from the programmers was named Dr. Been announced to the room. The techs and chemists with her dispersed throughout the room quickly, but only to grab their stuff and start leaving. “You sober yet, Wrecker?” asked Dr. Been.

“...Mostly.” Niam croaked weakly.

Her eyes darted around the room, narrowed so slightly.

“Where are the programmers?”

“...Still on their break, I guess,” Niam proffered innocently, trying not to let on how he knew.

Dr. Been exhaled deeply and massaged her temple. “You’ve got to be kidding me. Most important part of the experiment, and no one’s around to do anything! I need them to fix the sensors!”

“Well, they seemed to think there was nothing wrong with the sensors,” Niam thought for a moment as he recollected, “or the readout, or the calculations, or the programs...”

“Impossible!” Dr. Been interjected, “the electron detectors absolutely must be incorrect! Give me that report,” she said as she motioned for the papers in Niam’s hand.

Immediately the stain on the front made her bunch her nose up. “Did you... spill beer on this in the half hour I was gone?”

“Yes,” Niam replied.

Dr. Been stared at him with bafflement, but ultimately resolved to finish the point she was making. She tapped at the underlined average speed of the electrons captured in the accelerator, “You see this number? This number is far, far too small for any collisions to have occurred, the nuclei would not meet with nearly enough speed. But surely collisions must have happened. What else could explain our energy readings?”

“That’s odd, isn’t it,” Niam admitted, wishing he had more to add.

“Exceptionally,” Dr. Been sighed and placed the data in a folder with her, “but oh well. Just another thing we’ll have to wait on. We’re calling out the techs to disassemble the accelerator so we can look at the blockages inside. It’ll be a long procedure because they’ll have to take precautions for any sort of unknown danger. Radioactivity, combustion, hydrophilia, we truly have no idea what’s in there. We’re free to go home for the next few days.”

“Cool,” Niam tried to comment casually, but his feet were still rooted to the spot, cemented by a feeling of guilt and responsibility.

“And Dr. Wrecker,” Dr. Been spoke suddenly, addressing Niam by his title, “this is the biggest part of our research we’ve been working towards for years. *Your* research paper

that *you* brought to me. Don't blow it now. I plead that while you take your time off, you don't do any drinking. I'm not demanding this of you as your lead, but as a friend. There's no telling where this experiment is going to go."

"O-Of course," Niam stammered, fully aware of how daunting the request appeared in his head. The desire to drink was one of the few things his memory had left intact after his episode at the bar.

"Take care, doctor," Dr. Been said earnestly as she turned to leave the room. Niam stayed where he stood, a feeling of relief washing over him as he was absolved of responsibility for the time being.

Dr. Been stopped at the top of the ramp and shouted, "the techs will turn out the lights soon, just so you're aware," and then she pushed out the lab doors and left. They swung near-shut, hovered for a moment, then slammed.

These inversions exist already, a voice started up in Niam's head like a paused video starting again after bumping the TV remote, *and they will be very familiar to the theoretical physicists among us*. And then it stopped once more. He couldn't remember what came next.

If he was going to live up to his duties, he needed to find his thesis paper and recover what he was in this lab for. Spurred on also by the desire to not be left in a dark lab, Niam left the building and sought to return home.

In the car, finding 'home' proved to be more of a problem for Niam than he expected. Here's what he has gathered thus far. He knew his home:

- Was small, because research funding has been inconsistent
- Was closer to the lab than the bar, something that has always irked him
- Had access to a vantage point, because he could make out blurry, panoramic, oil-painted images of the city in his head
- And was closely tied to the number 40 somehow

To conclude, he could assume he lived in an apartment somewhere. The where was difficult, but he eventually placed it about six and a half miles from the lab, towards a small residential zone surrounded by commercial real estate.

The room numbered *40* had to be his, then. He was glad to find a key also numbered *40* attached to his keyring along with a charm depicting the symbol *Zr*, and it opened the door satisfactorily.

His apartment was unsatisfactory, however. It carried the ethos of an absent man. It wasn't half as atrociously littered-beyond-recognition as his car, but there were thick layers of dust on most surfaces of the room except the sad, sagging green couch which had stains in the place of dust. A familiar throne of wallowing, its cradle tempted Niam even now.

The abode greatly resembled the post-party break room, to describe it in shorthand. Same cans, same spills, same crushed boxes, same air of guilt. Gazing upon it now as if it were his first time ever seeing it, Niam's hairs stood on the back of his neck. The key worked, it was indeed his home. But it was not homely.

Yet there was no time to dwell. Emboldened by that creeping fear of forgetting who he was that had been haunting him all day, Niam sought to either find a copy of his thesis

paper lying around, or at least find out which college he had attended so he could request a copy.

There was a personal computer in his bedroom, next to the overflowing hamper and stack of unread books. His first plan was to simply search up his name along with 'doctorate thesis paper' and hope it was publicly accessible in some archive, as most thesis papers were. But as he should've known, that level of simplicity would never be granted to him. For some reason or another, nothing turned up. It was not publicly discoverable.

Someone must have it out for me, he grimaced to himself sardonically.

So instead of the convenience of technology, he would have to search his cramped shelves and closets for some sort of letter or diploma that could point him in the right direction as to which college to inquire to. This could be a multi-hour process, and it was already well after noon. To add onto this, he could not remember anything before noon, so he was unsure if he had eaten a single piece of solid food all day.

Dinner would have to be the buffer between him and progress. Unfortunately for the doctor, however, he could see as he checked his fridge that he must not have been shopping for some time. His choices were slim.

Throughout the morning of the next day after a somber breakfast of one yogurt cup, Niam had been tearing his already messy apartment upside-down in search of his college clue.

In time, his search was fruitful in the back of his bedroom closet, in a box that contained dusty documents. Niam would be the first to admit he was not a methodical man. Admittedly maybe not an ideal trait for a chemist, but the fact was there was no chance he was going to meticulously scan every document in this folder. It would've killed the flow of his mind and quashed his motivation to stand.

So it was by sheer chance seemingly that a letter flitted out of the folder stamped with red letters comically reading 'IMPORTANT'. He shifted the weight of the document box back onto the shelf and picked the letter up from off the floor. At the top of the letter it bore the insignia of an electric 'S' plastered over an oil rig. Circled around this imagery were the words: 'INTEGRITY. TRADITION. TRUST.'

'Dear Doctor Sybil Been and doctorate candidate Niam Wrecker,' it read, 'at the Windslow University of Sciences,' paragraph break. Niam could've stopped there with the info he needed, but it was curiosity at the 'importance' of this letter that had caused him to pick it up in the first place. He read on.

'We hope this notice finds you well and you give it the utmost attention it deserves. We are from the Committee of Rational American Energy. It has come to our attention that your research errs toward trampling on our patented ground.

The pursuit of penetrating the Dirac Sea for use of renewable energy files decisively under our registered patents and trademarks. We request that you render your research null, cancel the publication of your thesis paper, and look elsewhere for topic to study. There is, for example, no shortage of work that needs to be done in the natural gas industry.

If you do not comply with these demands, we may be forced to take legal action, and the Windslow University of Sciences with whom we have a great relationship and have donated to several times to demonstrate our support will gladly take our side in this matter and provide us with the relevant information, proceedings, and names.

We do not mean to scare you or threaten you, merely warn you of coming too close to our protected territory. Please duly consider,

-R. Dwight, Chairman'

Following that there was standard legal affair and a return address. Niam scanned it all quickly and then when he finished, sat the letter on his table. He sat down on the chair in front of it.

This sunk his search into considerably murkier waters. Was he looking for the thesis paper mentioned in this letter, or had he complied with the demands and started a new, unrelated thesis paper? Did he even remember what the Dirac Sea is?

Regardless, it was clear that the Windslow University of Sciences was where he'd request a copy of his thesis paper from, whatever it may contain. He'd make a formal request online, and he could quit thinking about it until it arrived. Great. Now he could enjoy his time off. Maybe he could go sleep in that sunshine field he had dreamt about back in the lab.

There was only one problem, and it became increasingly apparent as he lied face-up on his couch watching his thoughts swim.

He had no hobbies.

Chapter 4 - Catalyst

At the least, Niam had no hobbies he could remember besides drinking. But after the trouble of his fugue state and the words of Dr. Been, for the first time in his life drinking didn't seem so appealing anymore. At least not recreationally. He was sure the need would come again.

Filling the time felt an impossible task. A whole hour passed with nothing but the quiet buzz of a building wired up with electronics. He had the insurmountable feeling that he had spent the past indescribable number of days sinking, and for the first time in weeks found some sort of piton to cling onto. For the time-being, he wasn't sinking any longer. It was time to piece things back together.

And that would mean doing things that felt new and uncomfortable, no matter how much that might agitate him. It was time, he supposed, to clean up his shitty apartment; starting with going around with a trash bag and picking up all the drinking detritus.

He groaned and stretched miserably, then fetched the bag and got to work. Bottles on counters, cans in crevices, it seemed almost like he fastidiously cleaned after himself when it came to any other kind of trash, but deliberately left the bottles and cans behind. Like some sort of tribute. But whatever purpose he could've had for that he was leaving behind now.

Change is good, right? Chemistry is the study of change. If anybody should be warrant to accepting change, Niam figured, it would have to be him.

He also drew the curtains and opened the window to his apartment, letting in a drafty breeze. It carried out the smell of wasting away on its crisp airs. Taking a break, Niam leaned against the window and looked out onto the semi-suburban city.

There was a fluidity to the way cars moved, bound by traffic laws much like how molecules are bound by rules. Another musing that wasn't new to him, but continuously recurred in the subconscious waiting to be acknowledged by the pilot in charge.

Even trying to set up the cleaning of his apartment as a symbolic cleaning of the mind, the distracted doctor couldn't shake an odd feeling of anxiety. *But, he shrugged, these things happen when you nearly forget who you are through freak amnesiac episodes.*

Standing here at the window doing nought but think, he felt his mouth turn dry for drink. It was compulsive to have something in his hand during times like these; but he had to stay sharp for his thesis paper, which shouldn't take more than twenty-four hours to be sent electronically.

Change is good, change is inevitable, he reaffirmed to himself repeatedly, *things can only get better.*

Maybe he should do a laundry wash, and finally crack open one of the unread books beside his bed. Some sort of historical piece.

He woke up the following day, crumpled in his best imitation of the letter C from a restless sleep. He lay in a mess of blankets; and his lab coat, which was still on the bed from two days prior where he had haphazardly thrown it after returning home. Typically this is

not good practice, but he hadn't handled any chemicals so he'd likely get away with his negligence for now.

He threw on lousy home-clothes and checked his computer. Sure enough, he had received an email response from the university with his paper attached. It would take the better part of three hours to finish reading through this, and as he had no quick-access to any printer, he would have to sit there in his cheap office chair staring at the screen. So be it.

It was a proposal for a new form of renewable energy, much like the letter from the Committee had suggested. The actual experiment was difficult to discern from the lengthy piece, however, and even the abstract felt too literal to the denotation of the word. Pages of theory with frequent mention of a "Dirac Sea"; seemingly a very important concept his mind had built a memory fence around.

He took to the internet with the term, and though he found results and understood the basic concept of the model, he was very confused as to how it pertained to his own theory. For one, it seemed a little outdated; it was a working theory that helped insinuate the existence of the positron, but referred to it as a "hole" in an "infinite sea of negative energy" rather than the antimatter particle that it is.

Yet despite this, Niam's thesis was rich with references to the Dirac Sea and its holes. Why? What did he know then that he didn't now?

It seemed that, somehow, the experiment he performed for his thesis would prove that positrons emerge by puncturing a hole through the Dirac Sea in the antiquated model.

More than a mathematical model, his paper suggests, but a perfectly, ontologically accurate one.

This experiment would involve vacuum-sealing an entire room; the people inside would have to wear pressure suits as they went about their work. Throughout the room, all manner of unusual meters and instruments were to be placed. It looked like a madman's attempt to build a robotic brain, with receptors for every kind of information imaginable. An undisguised attempt to throw a hundred darts at a wall and pray one sticks.

Could there be any method to the madness? Niam had no way of remembering. Assuming it all went exactly as listed here, and there was no reason to believe otherwise, he had been one of those people in pressurized suits. But where could they possibly have gotten the funding to vacuum seal a whole lab space? Wouldn't such a thing need to be custom-built?

This uncertainty formed a clearly defined hole within Niam's gut. Something surely must've happened, and yet despite it being his own life, he could remember none of it. It would seem this mystery was not something he'd be able to crack today.

And to even further complicate matters, this was only trial one of the experiment: that to prove holes in the Dirac Sea. The second part was to prove its renewable energy implications. That was unusual and seemed like an incredible leap. It reeked of mental overconfidence, an irrational belief that one's own work has no choice but to save the world.

And to be criticizing oneself on this matter, one could infer the tragic extent of it.

But still, he at least knew now about the Dirac Sea, which he apparently thought must be of the utmost importance to this experiment at some point, so he was that much closer to understanding the significance of the collider blockage.

Hopefully, close enough that he could survive a discussion around the collider's findings in the next couple days.

The day passed, and so too did the day following it. It was time to return to the lab and find out what was lying inside the collider. The drive was as disparaging as ever, as was trying to squeeze into his undersized parking spot. There was birdsong in the air.

Niam entered the same lab, pushing the same door, but as soon as he entered he was crowded by chemists and a safety helmet was forced onto his head by Dr. Been.

"You're a little late, but at least you showed up," she spoke quickly, "put your PPE on as fast as you can, you're going to want to see this. This is exactly what we've been working towards. It's real."

Niam obliged, figuring that his easiest way through this was the path of least resistance. Like conductivity. It wasn't that he didn't recognize the importance of his work, of course, just that he no longer felt like the person responsible for it. And his efforts to quit the drink hadn't made his mind any sharper, that was usually due out after another couple weeks and a life of boredom.

He wordlessly followed the antsy group of chemists and techs through the pale green door he had seen them disappear into a few days prior; it was time to face the music.

There, in a tunnel, was the particle collider. A thick bolted carbon steel pipe that snaked its way through its kilometers of housing. The crowd, with Niam included, sidled up alongside it to navigate the tunnel.

It was abnormal for anyone to be inside the tunnels that housed the collider except for maintenance workers, and certainly never this many at once. The walkways were thin such that the large group had to walk in pairs in a line in order to fit. It was lit only with yellow emergency lights that bathed the cement walls and mixed into an infectious green, and Footsteps reverberated through the hollow tunnel like a marching band.

It was a longer walk to the blockage than Niam would've hoped. He walked near the front of the line alongside Dr. Been, with only a pair of techs in their prosaically greasy jumpsuits and work boots leading the way ahead of them and six or so chemists behind them.

Incredibly however, with no map to reference, Niam could still tell how close they were to the blockage by how proportionally dense the hole in his stomach became. The human body is commonly cited as having more than the five senses in modern day, including things such as balance and temperature; the unreliable doctor had a unique sense for responsibility.

Deeper, deeper the feeling sank. The air which should have smelled at worst like the must of concrete was marked instead by an indefinable acidity. Niam walked forward with his head down for most of the trip while others chattered excitedly.

"I've never seen anything like it..." one chemist muttered to another.

“I’ll be honest, I didn’t expect this to experiment to yield anything, I was just in it for the job. To be a part of a discovery like this...”

“Dr. Been and Dr. Wrecker are mad scientists, through-and-through. But you won’t get anywhere in this field any other way,” whispers broke out in another pair.

“Whatever this is, it’s fascinating. But I won’t believe Dr. Wrecker’s rambling unfounded theories on renewable energy until I see it,” the other chemist of the pair agreed.

So it was true then. There would be some big discovery waiting for Niam in this tunnel. Not an error to laugh off and give up on, but a real discovery that would thrust him to the forefront of action—whether he was prepared and willing or not.

And here it was.

The top paneling of this segment of the collider pipe was unbolted and pried off, lying against the wall across from the side we were walking on. The techs jumped the walkway rail and slid in closer to the pipe.

Dr. Been stopped expectantly and gestured toward the inside of the pipe. Dr. Wrecker leaned over the rail to look inside accordingly.

Jagged and crystalline, it was as colorless a compound as most made in a lab; most likely absorbing light spectra higher than that of visible light. Larger than a pebble, but no larger than a smart phone. One would not be blamed for mistaking it for an ordinary organic product, as it had no distinct visual indicators to set it apart.

Sans one thing. An odd, permeating film that wrapped around the crystal-like compound almost like a blanket, as if someone had thrown plastic wrapping over it and left it out to dry.

Niam pushed his glasses up his nose, trying to think of something important to say.

“That’s a superheavy element, right? Should all of us really be this close to it? Radioactivity.”

“Superheavy *antielement*,” Dr. Been corrected him congenially, “and Greg, if you could show Dr. Wrecker the Geiger counter on your belt,” she added.

The more mustache-endowed of the two techs took a Geiger counter off his tool belt and angled the reading so Niam could see it from the walkway. It was silent, and read zero.

“So... 140 antiprotons... in the ballpark of 200-plus antineutrons... and, one would assume: 140 positrons,” the so-called ‘violet-souled’ chemist from days prior commented to herself, awestruck.

“The Dirac Sea has been sailed,” Dr. Been agreed, the triumphant glow of vindication clear in her eyes. “I told you this project would be worth interning for, Violet.”

Violet was just her name, then. Not her soul color. *Don’t be stupid*, Niam chastised himself.

“But there is one thing I’m confused about, if I may, and I’m sure it’s the thing on all of our minds,” Violet started suddenly. “If it’s really made of antimatter, why isn’t it annihilating on contact with all the matter around us? Shouldn’t it have destroyed the whole lab as soon as we made it?”

Which was true. When matter and antimatter collide they annihilate one another, releasing a great deal of Gamma radiation.

“...Yes, I suppose it should. Instead it’s just got that clear film on it,” Wrecker added uncertainly: “did somebody... y’know, cover it with that?”

Dr. Been shook her head. “No, whatever it is, it was present when the techs cracked the pipe open—or so I’m told.”

“So it’s part of it? Or is it a whole other compound that formed around our antielement?” Violet proffered possibilities.

Suddenly, Niam’s ears began ringing faintly and he subtly clung to the yellow railing for support. A cold chill passed through his body.

“Are we sure it’s not emitting toxic gases?” he asked, looking around. But the rest of the researchers and techs stood like nothing was happening, and indeed did not even notice his dizzy spell.

“It is, ostensibly, entirely inert. Which is nothing short of a miracle, because we’d all be dead right now if it weren’t. Even still...” Dr. Been trailed off.

“Even still... why was it emitting energy signatures,” Niam finished for her in a sort of strange dizziness that made him feel as if he was above clouds. In this trancelike state, he gripped the rail tightly and swung himself over down next to the techs. “Gamma radiation, from particle annihilation. It would be massively destructive had it occurred here. So the energy had to come from something else.”

The words were flowing not from his conscious mind. He reached out with his gloved hand to the mysterious sample, and rustled the film between his digits.

“The faint, yet consistent reading,” he continued, “is the result of the creation of two new materials today. Our antielement; which I propose we deem Element-Minus-140 until we can dub it a proper name in our report; and this film here. It wasn’t placed here, it was formed here, I believe. And it is made of neither matter, nor antimatter.”

“What? That is utterly unfounded,” Violet called down.

“Has he been drinking again?” another chemist chided from the group.

“Doing worse than alcohol, by the sounds of it,” another piled on.

“I’m sorry, am I to understand we’ve been making something we thought would explode and kill everyone all this time? What the fuck? Why? With no precautions? No bunker? For god’s sake I need to retire soon,” one of the techs whispered to the other.

“This does seem farfetched,” Dr. Been agreed, “but I’ve seen Dr. Wrecker theorize all matter of madness and end up on some solid ground. Tell us then: if not matter, nor antimatter, what could it possibly be?” she directed her question to Niam.

What stream of consciousness Niam had just been on, however, had passed. “I guess that’s for us to find out,” he answered sheepishly, “but I propose it’s serving as some sort of buffer between the antimatter inside, and the matter that makes up all of us here on the outside. Should we find a way to rip, tear, melt, evaporate, or otherwise remove the film, then... then annihilation would promptly occur!” and with excitement Niam began

remembering the thesis he had read, *his* thesis he had written. It spurred him onward like a train.

“And should we be able to mass produce Element-Minus-140, and control how this film is removed, and condense it, contain it, *control* it; we have antimatter for an antimatter rocket! Megatons of easily storable energy, activatable in an instant!! It’s the future of renewable energy!”

The other chemists were whispering amongst themselves, and sharing the occasional half-concealed chuckle. Some found it less amusing, some even looked scared. The progression of madness in the mind was a frightening happening.

“This all assuming that this film is the anomaly you say it is,” Dr. Been stated matter-of-factly. “What you’re saying is, after all, only a guess.”

“There’s no doubt whatever we’ve made here is extraordinary. If it’s Element-140, and it’s as stable as it appears, that’s unprecedented in of itself. But what you’re suggesting seems like too many leaps with no basis. Surely we should stick with the miraculous discovery we *do* have before we start inventing more that haven’t happened yet?” Violet voiced.

“But then what’s the film? What of the energy signature?” Niam replied, thoroughly ignited by the excitement of recognizing his own theory in real life. It had felt like fiction when he read it in the detached voice that was apparently his, but it felt now like the reification of a holy text just as he’d always foreseen it.

“Unfortunately, not being able to explain otherwise does not serve as proof. We’ll send it to the materials lab and give them your theories as warnings to consider. Throughout the rest of the week here, the techs will work on uncovering the other samples so we can remove them as well. Let’s take five,” declared Dr. Been.

Niam’s excitement was halted like a braking train.

“Are you kidding? This is exactly what I was writing about! I know for sure that this *non-matter* film, whatever it is, can be breached somehow! Of course it can!”

“I figure you’re probably right about that. But even if it does release a huge amount of energy, it’s not exactly cost-effective, is it? We had to run a particle collider this large just to get a few samples of it,” Violet pointed out.

“And there aren’t any engines that could even take that much gamma radiation all at once either,” one of the techs added before awkwardly creaking: “I follow stuff like that.”

Niam stood, threatened, his dissenters calmly giving him disapproving looks that seemed to distort to him like funhouse mirrors. Nothing in his head and in the world matched except for the antimatter. They couldn’t take this away from him.

He went to get another word in, but the techs were already climbing back over the rail, and Dr. Been began leading the researchers back the way they came.

“Feel free to observe for as long as you like, but our work day here is over until we can do the paperwork and get this processed for the Materials Department; we won’t be able to handle something like this here in Windslow,” Dr. Been called out behind her.

“There’ll be some hazard workers swinging by to seal up the samples in the coming hours.”

Niam silently watched them go. Then, turned back towards the colorless compound inside the collider. He couldn't be patient, not now. There was exigence in his spine, where it was creeping the other day now it was exploding.

He couldn't stop himself from grabbing the sample from the collider and turning it around in his hand, caressing it. It was a solid chunk, dense, heavy for its size. Holding something like this was in the realm of the impossible. Where everything in the world was meant to sink down, this would be akin to walking on the ceiling. Novelty like this, novelty at the ontological mind-breaking subatomic level, wasn't meant to be left lying around so that some pedestrians in rubber suits could lock it in a case and ship it away—so he slipped it into the pocket of his lab coat.

There was just no time to waste. He would take it to the materials lab himself. There had to be some way to remove the film, and ideally not be eviscerated in a high-energy radioactive explosion in the process. Of course there was, he already knew this. The only question was a matter of how.

He would have to backtrack through all the tunnel, and from there the material science lab awaited him somewhere on the first floor, in one of the rooms he had passed so many times before.

Niam crept through the halls and checked corners before he turned them, feeling spurred into surreptitiousness with his scientifically unexplained prize in his pocket; even if by all accounts he had the authority to be in the lab and wouldn't be stopped anyway.

As he passed he would peek through the windows of each room looking for the materials science lab's signature big-ass poking-and-prodding machines that would tell it apart.

He would, after all, need the most blast-proof, biggest-ass test machine he could find should he figure out how to remove the film around his sample. The frosted windows blurred the image of the dark rooms ever so slightly, but when he arrived at the correct room, he could still make out the distinct shape of the glovebox; a device appropriately named for being a large box with sealed gloves that let you manipulate whatever you put inside.

Though as stubborn as any heavy door was, the door to the lab eventually gave in with a heave. Someone had left it unlocked. Strange, but auspicious. After assuring no one tailed him, he turned the LED lights on with a shutter. The workspace was his. He threw his keychain onto the key tray, so as to avoid any electromagnetic interference with his car fob.

He was already wearing most of the proper protective gear from his trip to the collider, all he had to do was strap off the helmet and switch out the gloves for a more dexterous nitrile pair.

The sample would go in the thickest, densely insulated, lead-lined box for high-grade science he could pick out of this room. But first, before he could work, he had to channel his element. He carried with him a cell phone, as people of the modern day do, and with it he could play music.

As much as Niam liked his sad-yet-hopeful British prog rock, it was not the mood he was looking for. He was in a lab, conducting an experiment he "shouldn't". He needed real,

rebellious, anarchy-praising rock-and-roll. The kind you could only get from disillusioned Russian youths, with a band name like *Skinned Knees*, or something to that effect.

Recklessness is not typically a valued trait in lab work. There are in fact few disciplines that *do* actively reward recklessness. But when fortune has it, it can be the tiebreaker, the unjammer, the stopgap stopper.

This principle would soon be seen in action as Niam stared down the sample, now behind thick, thick layers of glass and lying on its side like a sick patient.

Where to begin? Though Niam was eager to unlock the sample's mysteries, in truth, figuring out how to remove the film and induce annihilation would not be the smartest idea. It was a small sample, couldn't be more than 100 grams, and yet annihilation with a sample of this size would still be somewhere around four or five megatons of force—equal to four or five million tons of TNT. Mushroom cloud levels of catastrophe. They don't make gloveboxes that can handle that.

In this sense, what the doctor was doing bordered on moronic at best and approached patently deranged at worst. A sample like this needed a specialized lab built around it with layers and layers of concrete deep underground, and remote-controlled proxies doing all the manipulating.

He was aware of this, but remained convinced he would be able to extrapolate some sort of vital knowledge by prodding it a little with funny instruments.

Just this once you will be spared of the details, but know it involved a lot of motions like incising, pulling, rustling, and trying to pop it open like a chip bag. Through all this, the film remained firm.

He tried a small stream of water from a wash bottle, but it had no effect. He considered retrieving an acid from storage, but he was certain the film he was dealing with was some novel new non-matter that reacted with neither matter nor antimatter, and as such it couldn't be expected to react with acid.

He narrowed his eyes at the glass obstinately just as the guitar-fueled bridge of the song he was listening to started. The singer belted about glass shards kneecapping someone—possibly how the band got their name.

What hadn't he tried? What hadn't he done to it? What forces hadn't he exerted onto it? He punched the box with exasperation, then glanced out the lab window in an antsy fit. He couldn't shake the feeling he was on a timer. Someone was out to get him, he was an expendable.

Just under the window, right next to the door where he left it, he saw his keys on the key tray. The keys he couldn't bring in because of magnetic interference.

Magnets. The most readily alterable of the four fundamental forces, and any good materials science lab should have a massive, high-powered cold magnet. Niam bolted to open the glovebox as fast as he could and take the sample to the high-powered magnet. After a brief moment of hesitation, he grabbed his phone as well, a portable portal to high-powered rock-and-roll: perfect for a high-powered magnet.

The magnet had its own room, attached to the mats lab. It was a large, cylindrical, lustrous metallic-looking thing encased inside a large, cylindrical, lustrous metallic-looking thing with yellow safety warnings pasted on it. High voltage, damages electronics, subzero temperatures, all the works. Tubes and wires ran in and out all over it, connecting it to tanks of pressurized and condensed liquid helium. The terminal that controlled it boasted graphical UI that looked, at best, a decade too old.

Placing the sample carelessly on the adjacent workbench, Niam rushed to get the magnet to open up by seemingly mashing buttons on the terminal. Somewhere in his brain he remember how to do this. And he remembered he liked magnets.

The top of the magnet hissed open like an ancient treasure. Niam rubbed his gloved hands together eagerly before grabbing the sample and placing it inside on a bed.

Close magnet. Loosen helium valve. Enable cooling. This part would take a minute. The doctor drummed his fingers rhythmically on the benchtop to the sounds of heavy bass. The magnet's temperature dropped lower, and lower, approaching somewhere around 20 Kelvin. Superconductivity range. Perfect for strong electromagnetism with no heat generated. Niam smirked with cocky confidence. There was intense freedom in working unsupervised.

Time to start the magnet. He didn't want to take the film off and cause a city-eradicating explosion, he just wanted proof that he could give it a little pull. Some evidence that it *could* be done. It's fine. He could just start the magnet once he got the signs he wanted, right? That's how lab-grade magnets work.

Come to think of it, what had he done that morning? Niam couldn't remember his day at all. Somnambulant as ever. He itched his nose.

On goes the magnet!

It started with a deep hum, then an intensifying whirring. The rock-and-roll from his phone began to distort and falter. Underneath the din, there was another sound. An unfathomably and undetectably high-pitched squealing, subatomic fabric ripping.

Leaning against the benchtop, Niam wished he had a drink right about now. He knew he was trying to stay sober turning these scientifically exciting times, but alcohol was synonymous with leisure. It was hard to be hanging back and not expect something in his hand.

To pass the time, Niam used a nearby clipboard to scribble notes about the experiment down sloppily.

Purpose: Just trying some things :)

Hypothesis: Magnet might do something

Reaction: None probably

The door flung open.

"Dr. Wrecker? What are you doing?" Violet asked, shocked but with a measured tone she forced when talking with someone who was her project senior.

Then the lights went out, and the magnet shut down and hissed.

Chapter 5 - Reaction

"Violet?" Niam asked dazedly in the now pitch black room.

Violet waited before responding, and for a moment only the dying hum of the failing magnet filled the room. "I was organizing the stockroom and I noticed the light was on in here," she explained. "What are you doing in here? Did a fuse just blow?"

"Maybe, probably," Niam dismissed casually.

Violet turned the flashlight on her phone on and stunned the doctor with the light.

"Were you running the magnet?"

"Yes, yes I was; I'm onto something big here," Niam replied as he began pacing in the beam of light cast upon him.

"With the antielement?" Violet ventured, a grim look of anticipation spreading across her face.

"With the antielement," Niam confirmed without any of the same graveness.

"You're really not supposed to be doing that. There's paperwork, and even more so, it's a patent threat to all of our lives! Dr. Been was worried you might do something like this, that's why you were supposed to stay sober!"

"I am sober, I haven't drank in days!" Niam sniffed.

"I can't be the one to put up with this," Violet sighed with a pained expression, "I'm going to go check on the fuse box. You can go speak with Dr. Been now or let it blow up later,

but she's not going to be happy with you either way. It's your job and your life, but this discovery is everyone's. I wish you'd take that into consideration," and she turned and left the room, leaving Niam in the dark.

With the power off, the locks on the magnet had disengaged as a built-in failsafe allowing it to be opened manually. He'd have to wait, though, as the magnet was still somewhere in the approximate range of 20 Kelvin.

So, he snatched his phone off the counter; which had stopped playing music several minutes ago and now wouldn't turn on properly; threw his hands in his coat pockets, and waited for the magnet to warm up in pitch darkness.

Once he figured it had been long enough, he reached instinctively around for safety gloves that were kept nearby and forced open the top hatch of the magnet. It was cold to the touch even through the insulation of the thick rubber gloves.

With the hatch open, Niam fished around inside for his precious sample. His hands rested on a hard, jagged, and cold object. Undoubtedly that had to be it, only, there was one thing: it felt different. Perhaps it was merely because he was feeling it through a glove, but the surfaces were unfamiliar. The small crystal he could before engulf entirely in his palm now took up the whole surface of it.

But in the dark it was impossible to be sure. He grasped; it was still so cold as to begin making his hand go numb through the glove. Then, he slipped it into his coat pocket without another thought. To be clear, it was ridiculously cold. Colder than any arctic ice wall—but it would probably be fine so long as it didn't make direct contact with his skin. Probably.

Then, he stormed out of the room, mistakenly smacking the door a few times before correctly finding the handle.

Nobody believed he was sober? Fine. He'd make that true. All his hard work, all his genius, and bureaucracy was still standing in his way. Feeling his way through the dark, he set off for the break room. There must be at least one beer left in the fridge. And if the power had gone out, he was losing time. That poor little beer could be atrophying to room temperature by the minute.

After an embarrassingly long time groping in the darkness, he found his way out of the lab, and the first thing he heard echoing through the hallways was shouting. Angry shouting. It was far, but audible. Unusually audible, as the ventilation was mute from lack of power.

Niam couldn't stop himself from theorizing. Maybe Violet had already managed to tell Dr. Been about his little extracurricular experiment. He increased the speed of his creep as much as he could without tripping over himself.

He was successful, and made it to the break room without much trouble. And, sure enough, there were still a couple cans of beer remaining in the fridge, sleek and half-chilled cylinders that if not rescued here now by his loving embrace, would've decayed away into a warm sticky tragedy. If nobody trusted him, alcohol always did.

But the dark was no place to drink, because then how could he gaze listlessly at objects that had disappointed him? Besides, he couldn't think over the high-pitched hum of a power outage. He resolved to take his debauchery outside, to his car.

It wasn't hard to find his way out of the building, the door at the end of the hallway streamed in sunlight at a harsh angle. The fear of being caught was still prevalent, and he only became more paranoid as the muffled shouting off in another wing of the building grew harsher, louder, and more frequent. It sounded like a large-scale argument between quite a handful of people, not too dissimilar to the dissertation he stumbled into after he'd been late on his lunch break a few days ago.

Stepping out of the darkness and into the open air, the starkness of the solar sun seared his eyes just as he would soon be searing his solar plexus with more sweet, sweet alcohol.

But upon arriving at his parking spot and seeing his car sitting there in direct sunlight, looking hot and old like a silver screen starlet in the modern day, Niam thought he might want to find somewhere else to drink to avoid heat stroke. He also checked the cans in his hand to make sure he hadn't already drank them or something, because that silver screen starlet comment was a bizarre comparison to make. Who says things like that?

Scanning the lot for somewhere nice to sit and wallow, his eyes wandered off to the ladder in the corner; the thin metal grate that typically kept it locked up instead mysteriously ajar. There was not a complex though process that resulted in his climbing of it. Were there some grand impetus, it would be relayed here to you in prose that thinks it's far wittier than it is, but he started forward with a kick in his step simply because he felt like being up high. But on some level, that's a human impulse, isn't it? It affects how you see the world in the most literal and immediate way possible. Plus, it's fun.

Up he went over the rungs, each just shy of scorching temperatures having all spent hours out in the heat of the sun. It was a one-handed climb with the near-empty beer case dangling from his other hand, tipping his weight slightly towards the left. When he finally heaved the case over himself onto the roof, and peeked his head over the top to look, he was greeted with more ventilation units, satellites, water tanks, solar panels, and skylights than he could count. It was a far cry from the flat and bald top you'd expect to see from most strip mall buildings out in the suburbs. He felt more at home here than he did among those barren buildings.

He found a nice patch of EPDM (ethylene propylene diene monomer) membrane roofing to plant himself on, right next to an angled skylight, and sat the case next to him. If the day were even a little hotter the roof would be totally inhospitable, but as it was it just pushed the boundary of uncomfortable and burned softly; which fared well, as Niam reasoned that being uncomfortable was the perfect state in which to anger-drink.

Tab up, tab down. Can up, can down. It wasn't refreshing in the same way an ice-cold beverage was, where one could picture ancient glaciers drip-feeding primordial and pure water down your throat as a special privilege that no other being in history has ever had access to. It was instead more akin to sticking your tongue to stripped bark and hoping to get some tree sap. But that's not why people drink alcohol. It was because it dulled harsh feelings.

And all that excitement and fear and anger from the tense lab proceedings melted away in the same half-hearted flow as the lukewarm beer. Even before the alcohol could hit

his bloodstream, just the idea of relapsing bore with it some significant mental relief. He closed his eyes and felt the sunshine.

You know what's hard? Chemistry. Niam's known that since he picked it out in college. High school chemistry classes, though that was more than a decade ago now for the doctor, oversimplify the science. They make it look easy. But once you really start dipping your toes into it, you learn that rules are tendencies, exceptions are the rule, and sometimes becoming recognized as learned in a field means sacrificing everything else in your life to get there. And also that you can't actually dip your toes into any of it because it's all toxic, acidic, basic, carcinogenic, or otherwise unkind to the human body.

And that goes two-fold for inventing new knowledge. You spend a lifetime chasing what's already been done so that you're properly prepared to go find your own thing. But nobody does prepare you for that, and maybe it's not something you can ever be prepared for.

The can grew lighter and his eyes grew heavier. The hard thoughts were still swirling around his head; the guilt emanating from the thought of what will happen when Dr. Been finds out about his misbehaving still attacking him. He was sick of being watched, controlled, but kept slipping up on his own. It was a conflict of mental interest. It would take more alcohol than one can to quell them. He tossed the first can haphazardly.

Onto the next, he muttered sardonically. This was not nearly as enjoyable as he had expected it to be. The responsibility of his discovery hung above him like a sword on a string, and all he wanted to do was run out from under its shadow. But in doing so he didn't feel better, only like he was pacing in circles, repeating old coping habits.

Tab up, tab down. Can up, can down. Thoughts could still leak in through poorly insulated cracks. For someone so chronically uncertain about his path in life, where did he well up the certainty over the antielement? *His* antielement. The thing that would save the world, and by extension, himself.

Maybe it was time to be realistic. He rolled his shoulders, taking in the sheer extent of their tenseness. He just wanted an out, proof that he was doing right. He wanted an easy answer; but there aren't any of those in this life. What he made was a society-ending bomb in a sack. Someone was bound to do it eventually, it just happened to be him.

He hurled the can against the wall, more deliberately than the last, sending a spattering of sticky warmed beer across the rubber top of the roof. It then ricocheted off the wall and landed a hand's length apart from where he'd thrown the other can.

His face pursed lightly as he thought about crying. He was crashing down fast. Color drained slightly from the world and his facial muscles were pulled a little taut. But just as he went to touch his face to make sure it was still there, a roar from behind him made him jump out of his skin.

In an instant, the grid boxes and AC units all whirled back to life with their ever vigilant diligence. The power was back. Despite his initial shock at the noise's appearance, and despite how long it took for him to calm down after, he was in some part grateful for the buzz that now hovered above the air. It helped with blocking out thoughts, which half his mind was committed towards.

But the other half, a neglected and mistreated half, was choosing now to make a loud stand for itself. This was the half tearing apart every veneer and furniture frame to find more thoughts to supply the guilt.

Already out of beer. Now he was just a sad idiot on a hot roof. How could a day like this get any worse? This was a serious question he tossed out recklessly into the murky cosmos, right down the strings of interconnected human consciousness: what could possibly make a day like this worse?

There's no valid experimentation that proves in such a thing as a murky sentient cosmos, or interconnected human consciousness. In truth, it was probably just drab coincidence that the following events ensued. But such as it is with people and stories, the irony was not lost on Niam.

It began with the return of the shouting, just audible over the hum of the rooftop appliances. Niam shook his heavy head about wildly trying to find the source. He flopped in a state of disorientation atop the nearby sunlight and peered down.

His pupils shrunk, cold sweat accumulated over the dewy sweat of a hot day, and his hands started shaking. His vision blurred and he had to put in extra effort to refocus and ensure he was even seeing what he believed he saw. It seemed inconceivable.

He used his hands to try to shield his eyes from the reflections on the glass and get a better view. Unmistakably, that was a gun. Some figure in black was pointing a gun at someone, someone in white. White like a lab coat.

Niam nearly fainted then and there, and the alcohol did not make resisting that urge any easier. He couldn't make out a word of the shouting, What does one do in a situation like this?

Thinking is hard; thinking while inebriated was very hard; thinking while panicked and inebriated was extremely hard; and worst of all, Niam felt the urge to go to the bathroom welling up from all that beer. This was about to be the worst day in recent memory—which incidentally, was the only memory he had.

"I'm not with those violent egomaniacs, I'm here to save your ass!" the leather jacketed man insisted in a faint Russian accent, holding a shotgun by the pump such that it was aimed at the ceiling. A shadow shifted above, but he didn't catch it as he was too busy adjusting his sunglasses. Indoors.

Dr. Been continued inching away slowly, her sweaty palms gripping the cafeteria tables as she tried to support herself.

"You dress like the textbook definition of a criminal, you're armed, and you've broken into our lab! How am I supposed to believe you?!"

"Because if I intended to shoot you, I would've done it already! With this!" he shook the shotgun for emphasis. "Those mercs have already swept up the tunnel and taken over most of the building. If I had to guess, they're not taking hostages or survivors. So as far as I can tell, you're the last egghead standing in the building. I need you on my side and fast if I'm going to get you out of here."

Dr. Been caught her breath and couldn't suppress a chuckle of disbelief. "If I wanted to kill you I would've done it already'? You call scientists 'eggheads'? Why do you talk like you were written by Hollywood? This can not be real!"

"Time's not on our side here. You want a reason to trust me? I'll give you a gun. I have this handgun here in a hidden pocket; should be intuitive enough even for someone with no firearm training."

"What? That's all I get? Why can't I have the shotgun?"

"Shotgun's for me. I only use shotguns. It's my THING."

Dr. Been sneered at him. Not intentionally, but out of sheer bafflement. "What? Well, why can't I have the machine gun on your hip?"

The intruder glanced down at the aforementioned Uzi hanging from his hip. He started unbuckling it from its holster angrily.

"You want this? Fine. Just have it. We need to get going," he hissed as he offered the gun.

Dr. Been took it by the handle and felt its weight carefully. "The power outage. The yelling. The missing sample. My missing researchers. You claim these are all the result of another, *tertiary* party of intruders, who are here to kill us all and destroy our research. You, however, show up out of nowhere claiming to be some sort of guardian angel."

The vigilante pressed himself against the wall adjacent to the cafeteria's doors, peeking around the corner as if he expected someone to start firing upon them. "More or

less. But to be clear: I'm no angel," this prompted Dr. Been to roll her eyes, "just call me Dan."

The lead scientist followed Dan's lead with uncertainty, using the wall as cover. "I absolutely would not believe you were it not for the nature of our research. I always knew certain parties would take issue with it, I just never suspected it might be this overt."

Dan pushed the cafeteria door open slowly and lowered his voice to a whisper. "Well, maybe you should have suspected. It's pretty standard M.O. for governments. Energy companies have the money. That means they have the lobbies and the funding to hire private military companies, like these musor."

He took the opportunity to hustle forward, creeping into the nearest lab on the left. The doctor had no choice but to follow behind quickly. "I have so many questions. The government is in on this? How do you know who these supposed intruders are? Why haven't I seen them yet? How do you plan on getting out of here?"

"Questions for later. All you need to know now is we're going to try to outwit those Dyavola bastards. We get the jump on them, take out their groups one-by-one, maybe we can eliminate them; save the lab, and the research. That's the optimistic Plan A. Plan B, if Plan A starts to seem impossible: we save whatever we can and flee on my motorcycle. We'll have to get on the roof and make a couple jumps, so I hope you're good at parkour."

Dr. Been shifted in her block pump shoes. "Uh, right. That's not my usual vocation as a woman in her sixties, but let come what will come I suppose."

“That’s the spirit. Now, until we know exactly where those mercs are, we should be saving whatever we can. Do you have a sample?”

“It was in the tunnels. If they’ve already taken the tunnels, they’ve already taken the sample.”

“Fucking shit-fuck! Research, then! Procedure, anything; they’re going to be trying to wipe it all. Can we get anything?”

Dr. Been winced. “No, anything physical was stored inside that lab, aside from whatever copies anyone individually brought home with them. But I assume if they’re cracking our database, they’ll find the names of everyone who worked on the project, and trace down their homes, destroy any remaining piece of evidence. Right?”

“Well, you catch on quick. I see you’re considered brilliant for a reason. I only wish you were not so right.”

“I wouldn’t believe it if we hadn’t already been strongarmed for pursuing this subject in the past. There was always something disconcertingly aggressive about their letters. I thought they were just trying to scare us off, but I suppose their bark had bite. What an incomprehensible level of cruelty.

“And to think, I left Dr. Wrecker in those tunnels no more than an hour ago. I hope he got to realize his theories must’ve all been right, before...” she trailed off. Dan crouched down and tapped her on the shoulder, pointing out the frosted glass.

“Shadows—someone’s coming! Get down.”

On cue, several indistinct but brawny figures crept in from down the hall. They were visible only through decorative slivers of transparency.

"I don't believe it..." Dr. Been muttered, "over here, there's a backroom where we keep the magnet. We can stay out of sight in there."

She tried to unlock the door with her keys, but to her surprise it was already unlocked. Had a careless tech left it unlocked? The magnet hadn't been needed for an experiment in months.

Even more surprising, the light was still on, and the magnet was open; but empty.

"Why is the magnet hatch open? Have they already been here? What could they have taken that would've been in the magnet?" Dr. Been began running through scenarios in her aloud.

"Huh? Why ask me? It's your lab," Dan hissed as he crept into the room behind the lead scientist. "They can't have been here yet. If there's something missing from that metal thing, someone else must've taken it."

Dan shut the doors as fast as he could, afraid the light leaking out of the room might give their spot away. When he turned around and reached for the lights, he saw Dr. Been leaning over a clipboard on the counter. Her face wore a gallows smile; shocked, outraged, disappointed, yet unable to do anything but smile.

"They don't have the sample," she said simply.

"What?"

“The mercenaries; they don’t have the sample. Or at least, I don’t think they do. My protégé took it. Illicitly.” She stifled a confused laugh. Not even she was sure why it was so funny.

Dan suddenly stood alert and slammed the light switch, shrouding them in darkness.

“Ready your gun,” he whispered, “I’ll be to your left. Don’t shoot to your left. Shoot in the direction of the door if—and only if—you hear it open. You have experience with guns?”

“I understand their general premise,” she whispered back, as she fingered around for the gun’s safety switch.

“For your sake, I hope that’s good enough.”

“How long do we plan on waiting before making a move...?”

Dan only pursed his lips.

A door opened somewhere nearby.

Niam resisted throwing up all over himself as he rolled off the cafeteria skylight. He could handle his alcohol well enough, even considering the speed at which he drank those two beers. But the crisis situation made all the blood sink from his face and into his stomach, where it tossed and turned and threatened to come back up. Maybe he should’ve had breakfast this morning. Or maybe he was glad he hadn’t.

Surely he had to do something, right? The police. The police were good for situations like this one. He pulled his phone from his pocket like a gun from its holster and started

tapping on the screen, only to realize it wouldn't turn on. The magnet had warped his phone beyond use.

That's what I get for never upgrading to a newer model, he groaned to himself.

What else was there to do, then? Just lie about like a sad sack? Maybe it was karmic punishment for doing those experiments he shouldn't have. Or drinking that alcohol he shouldn't have. Or never meeting anyone quite on their level like he should have. Now all his coworkers would die because of him, in some roundabout cosmic way.

No, he didn't know why someone with a gun was in the cafeteria, and wasn't in the right state of mind to think about it. He stumbled to his feet pathetically much like a toddler climbing a chair, and stumbled step by step back to the ladder.

The stumbling and the incoordination, it wasn't necessarily a result of how drunk he was. He was used to handling alcohol. It was more the result of the unbearable weight of not making the cut. There's a way to live, and he kept fucking about around it.

The ladder's arms rose and wrapped back around to hold onto the roof, and on one of these arms Niam stopped to lean and rest. The sun behind him cast a shadow growing out of the laboratory's. It looked as blurred and fuzzy as he felt.

He would've loved to have dwelled on that imagery for a while. That was exactly what he was in the mood for. But instead, he was forced to take count of the fact that the lab door shot open at that moment, and a gaggle of burly men in jumpsuits and leather jackets marched out with their guns pointed out. They moved like ants, checking corners and confirming angles with a silent hand signal denoting 'safe'.

Niam watched with dry eyes. Just wickedly dry eyes. At every turn his body was finding new processes to impair his functioning. The movements of the men melted together like balding middle-aged comets.

Suddenly, they froze, and Niam froze too. One, possibly the leader due to his most authoritative handlebar mustache, twitched his arm. It was barely a movement at all, and there was no chance the scientist made it out from his perch. Yet despite that, he did get the horrible ball of malintent in his stomach and that lurching feeling that told him he should probably back away.

The muscle twitch was motioning towards Niam's shadow. He had been noticed. On pure hunch alone, the doctor leapt backwards just as he heard indistinct shouting in Russian. They knew he was up there. They knew for sure.

They'd probably already killed all his coworkers. They were finally coming to collect for him, the immoral Copernican center of the universe from which all negativity stems. If he had half a conscience less, he'd turn himself in. Get what he gets. But having graduated into becoming a full-time archon of pure negativity, he didn't make choices like that. He knew what he had to do because it's what he does best: run.

The cafeteria skylight had an opening mechanism to allow for the venting of fresh air in the event of the of a dangerous gas flowing through the building if the ventilation gets blocked, or maybe to ward off the stench of some of the worst the cafeteria had to offer. However, it was not designed to be opened from the outside in standard procedure, because that would be a serious breach of security.

Niam dived down by the mechanism in blind panic. A dull metal box connected to a miniature motor, locked with a slot so corroded with dirt that it'd be a miracle if even the correct key could fit inside. He gave it a couple solid pounds, but to no surprise and much ire, it did not budge.

He peeked over his shoulder in time for his body to find more beads of nervous sweat to speckle across his face. His assailants hadn't made it up the ladder yet, but there was no doubt in his mind that they were trying.

There were few places to run on a roof. Left he looked, at the gate he had entered from that morning. It was wide open. Right he looked, at the various power boxes and machines growing from out the top the lab like mechanical tumors. Niam felt a lot like he had a tumor of his own at that moment, what with the pounding migraine all this stress was giving him.

He looked behind him, over the top of a few water canisters, and noticed an unfamiliar crevice between the building's side and the fence that surrounded the lab, wide enough to be an alleyway. Niam had no clue where it could lead; deliveries were bound further ahead, at the adjoining warehouse.

Feeling time slipping away by the moment, he scrambled over the skylight (burning his hands slightly in the process) and peered down into the alley. There were a couple obligatory dumpsters that any mysterious and grimy alleyway needed to earn its stripes.

Niam figured that did make sense now that he thought about it. This alley was connected to the cafeteria, after all. Having some bins for food waste was only natural.

Getting a garbage truck into an alley this small must be a massive pain though, especially since it was shut up with padlock and chain link fence.

An earsplitting crack exploded in the air and something wet started spraying wildly into Niam's face, blinding his glasses like a windshield and flattening his hair to his head. For a moment he thought it was his own blood, but it was far too cold.

Without any more time to think, he leapt down into the alleyway, aiming for the soft refuse below to cushion his fall. But as it turns out, bags full of cans, plastic cutlery, and other abject junk were not that comfortable—and whatever he had just landed on his pocket REALLY left a bruise.

He fought his way out of the dumpster and landed on the asphalt a foul-smelling mess. He then used whatever was near to help himself back to his feet, and looked around him through blurry blobs.

Light formed matrices through the chain link fence. Rats avoided an alley like this because of the smell of chemicals. Cockroaches didn't mind. And skulking against the wall on a tilt like it was trying to hide was a matte black motorcycle, two magnificent wheels and a gleaming oil tank.

Niam blinked twice. Motorcycle? Motorcycle was strange. His aggressors shouted angrily at one another from above. Niam blinked some more.

A pale green door was marked as *KITCHEN*. A nifty yellow square denoted a nearby box as the breaker, though the fact that it was wide open and looked very much like a breaker box would've given that away regardless.

Instinctively, Niam rushed for the door and pulled hard, but someone had done their job correctly and locked it. When it came to doing jobs correctly, no one ever seemed to have issues but him.

Denied entry at the door, he was forced to escape further into the alleyway to escape the voices above. Though the men likely wouldn't jump into the trash after him, they would not exactly need to get close to inflict harm given their armaments.

Pavement flew past, bobbing closer and further from Niam's face as he stumbled like a madman; he had no idea where this alley would exit out to, only a vague light ahead. More doors occasionally protruded from the building, and he'd stop to try each one. Repeatedly he was locked out. It was starting to feel like a joke.

Screeching projectiles creating new divots in the weathered concrete confirmed that his assailants had reobtained sight on him. Thankfully, it must've been a difficult angle to fire from.

At last, Niam plunged helplessly onto a door handle, and it gave and let him into one of the chemical storerooms. He could afford a brief moment of decompression as he tried to figure out which closet he was in.

At this moment, he wasn't sure whether he was more slick from the exploding water canister, or his own sweat. The fact that he was being chased by firearm-wielding mystery intruders should've shocked him to his core—and sure, it's not *exactly* what he had been expecting when he had come in for work this morning.

But for some reason, he was not as startled as he felt he ought to be. He had been living life on high nerves this past week, and these were his just desserts. He made the impossible, he pushed without permission, and now someone had come to collect. In some flagellant state of affairs, it felt like just karmic punishment.

If an outsider could look inside his mind, he may appear irrational or deranged. But following how he had been feeling, this all made just the right amount of sense. Life really *does* follow patterns after all, perhaps things really *must* happen for a reason, and this was his wings being melted for soaring too close to the sun.

His hands were burning up with sweat beneath his nitrile gloves, and he shook them out of instinctual discomfort. The storeroom had a homely feel. It was a quiet recess from the lab.

Carefully, he navigated around the outlines of packed shelves. His discovery was in danger, and anything would fly if it was done in the name of protecting the most important thing he had ever done in his life. Nobody could take this away.

He made a few choice selections of the room's many capped bottles, slipped them into his other pocket (not recommended for those interested in following proper lab safety), and then found his way out and into a lab space with sinks and fume hoods. It was a general-purpose room without specialized machinery.

Niam knew he couldn't stop and breathe yet, given he had seen through the skylight that there were armed attackers inside as well. He just had to sneak back out the side, make it to his car, and drive away. The number one priority was to protect his discovery.

Who knows where he'd actually drive to. Home, maybe. To sleep for a week. Or the bar. He'd figure it out after. Always after.

He crept up to the glass door and peered through; no sight of any leather jackets or flailing firearms, so he continued on. He exited from a lab adjacent to the staircase leading to the particle collider, which he approached slowly with the frantic glancing left and right of a savanna gazelle, hyperconscious of the slight resonance of his footsteps: even through the ventilation, the hall had taken on an eerie silence that seemed to amplify their presence.

Scratch that about the eerie silence: a burly surge of middle-aged balding men in ballistic vests pushed into view directly down the hall from Niam, whom they noticed on the spot and picked up their rifles to begin firing at without a moment's hesitation.

With reaction times exceeding that of the average drunk man, he tripped up the stairs away from the threat; bullets chasing after his shadow. Once again he found himself at those heavy push-bar doors, and he flung himself into one of the levers with enough velocity to leave a nasty bruise on his shoulder.

To the left, down the ramp, that was a dead end. Niam's eyes fell on the door to the right, the one that led into the tunnels that housed the particle collider. It was one big loop, technically, but would surely buy him more time. If he was lucky, there may even be a maintenance door or hatch he could exit out of.

He didn't love it, but he also didn't have the capacity to think very hard about it right now. He threw open the door and headed for the particle collider.

Dan and the doctor froze completely at the sound of the door opening. It wasn't clear to either of them just how close it was, but any doors opening could signify danger.

The following moments dripped by like a loose stopcock. The pair were in such a state of fear-paralyzed hypervigilance that they couldn't spare one glance at each other, eyes trained on the door in front of them.

At long last the silence was obliterated impudently by the unmistakable air-tearing cries of bullets leaving their casing. This, too, was frighteningly nearby.

Finally, Dan snapped toward his researcher rescuer. "That's the only distraction we're gonna get, let's move!" he enthused with the candor of frightful anticipation, quickly reaching for the door handle.

Dr. Been followed, but her mind was piecing together a different thought. "If they're still firing, then someone else is—or was—alive. If you're trying to save this project, shouldn't we try to save them?" out of understanding of this kind of man's archetype she expected resistance and pragmatic appeals to a 'greater good', but to her surprise...

"Yeah, you're right."

Dan pointed through the frosted lab glass at the blurry shape of the tail-end of a unit of PMC perpetrators, then raised his shotgun and took aim. He was steady, not an errant twitch in his fingers, his shoulders squared. But no matter how much practice you've had before, pulling the trigger always had a bitter sting to it.

Dr. Been quickly tried to adopt a similar stance as soon as she registered what was about to happen, which she was halfway to being successful in by the time Dan fired a

cavalcade of pellets that exploded through the glass and flew down the hallway at the unsuspecting intruders.

Without waiting to see what happened, Dan ducked under the lab bench in front of him, which Dr. Been copied as well. If there was one thing her years of chemistry had taught her, well, it was that one thing was many things and that no matter how much you know, you know nothing. But more specifically, the applicable thing here was how to observe reactions.

“Don’t you think we’re a little cornered—” but the rest of her sentence was drowned out by the torrential rain of terror that flew overhead.

“If someone’s getting shot at, you don’t have much time to do something!” Dan responded, though he had little hope of being heard through the bullet storm. “Ради всего святого, they love wasting ammo, don’t they?!” he added in vain.

The gunfire finally died down and heavy boots hit the floor. If they were heading for this lab, there were only moments to act.

Dan stayed low and retreated further into the lab space hoping to use the rows of lab benches as obfuscation. Dr. Been did not follow. Instead, she approached one of the fume hoods and started fishing for keys in her pocket. Dan glanced behind him, and his confusion was obvious even from behind his indoor sunglasses.

Once she had found the right one, Dr. Been unlocked the fume hood, raised its glass barrier, sat up on the space she’d opened up, and then pulled her legs inside. She had just managed to get inside as the PMC group breached the door and flooded the room.

Dr. Been tried to find a position where the recoil of her submachine gun wouldn't be a problem, scooting around some rubber tubing dangling from a water spout and ultimately settling on a spot where her back was supported against the wall and her gun stock was nestled against her shoulder just as the invaders came into view. In the darkness of the fume hood, she was thankfully obscured.

In a matter of moments, they had cleared most of the room and were approaching the bench that Dan was hiding behind. If something wasn't done now, there was not going to be anything left to do.

Dr. Been grabbed the loose end of the rubber tubing before reaching out of the fume hood and twisting the knob that dictated the flow of water from the nozzle.

In an instant, a powerful stream emerged from the shadow of the fume hood and, where it landed, it began pooling rapidly. It was a smaller lab with little foot space and no drain, so by the time the mercs had realized what was happening, the floor had already begun to flood.

Dr. Been resolved to get this obvious safety hazard fixed in the future, but as of now it was a feature of the room.

The mercs were shocked by the sudden appearance of the water, but within the fume hood Dr. Been was obscured—no reason for them to begin firing. After a couple short miscommunications, they agreed to send someone to check on the presumed malfunction.

With the attention now shifted away from Dan and the danger now approaching the doctor, it was his turn to take action. With water working its way up his boots, he couldn't make any movements without creating noise.

His eyes darted around the room looking for anything he could use.

Whiteboard with frighteningly large molecular structures sketched on its face. Water basin with soap and scrubber sponge. Drawers, filled no doubt with all manner of chemically applicable apparatuses. Or as Dan may put it, "nerd stuff".

Finally, his eyes rested on an electrical outlet poking its head out hazardously from beneath the lab bench like a mouse. It wasn't dangerous yet, the internal breaker would've switched. But if he could pry it open...

The mercs now drew close to the fume hood in which Dr. Been hid. One of them, particularly fat, panted labored breaths stained with booze. It flooded outwards into the room invisibly and coaxed out the feeling of dirty brotherhood amongst the assailants.

To each other, they were brothers of circumstance on another job.

Dan was prying the panel off the outlet just above the water using a pocket knife. He wasn't a chemist, but he knew water and electronics didn't mix, right? How much electricity did you need for how much water? He didn't know, but even if it wouldn't turn the whole room into an electric death trap, surely it would at least cause enough of an explosion to distract someone.

The paneling came off with a satisfying pop, and in one fluid motion he sat up onto the lab bench he had been taking cover behind and dropped the outlet into the water.

The world could've been shaken by the unimpressive plopping sound the outlet made as it sank into the water and rather anticlimactically did not explode.

Dan was not aware of the differences between distilled water and tap water. Distilled water contained no minerals, and as such, did not conduct electricity.

A slinkier merc with an AK-47 whipped around, his face obscured by a ski mask but his eyes narrowed with middling age.

Dan blasted his shotgun with the extemporaneous haste of a man in a flooding room full of firearms, the stock flying back into his stomach with enough force to knock him off his perch on the lab bench and into the rising water. A cried yelp told him someone must've been hit.

Bullets flew over and just missed him. Head against the floor, the water was now high enough to begin touching the tips of his ears. He could hear the wading movements of the encroaching mercenaries as boot slapped against growing pond.

With his back to the floor, Dan ejected the shell and shot wildly at the LED above, dimming the room and sending shards of hard plastic casing cascading down.

With the gunfire drawing all attention away from the water, the heat had been taken off Dr. Been; whom was now peering out from beneath the glass of the fume hood.

She readjusted the sweaty grip she had on the handle of her SMG, stretching each finger nervously. Should she pull the trigger? What were the repercussions of taking another's life, or of giving her position away?

She shifted back and planted the gun's stock against the back of the fume hood so as to control the recoil. It was a difficult position to aim from, but chemists had a way of eyeballing measurements.

The trigger's surface was smooth and slick. Stray water droplets from the hissing rubber snake speckled the lens of her glasses. Like science, sometimes life required risks.

Red hot bullet casings rocketed off and around the walls of the fume hood like popcorn in a kettle.

A cried yelp and man-sized splash told her she must've hit someone.

Realizing they were pincered, the hired arms took up defensive positions behind the room's benches.

The light Dan had shot flickered cinematically with its last legs of life. The wiry merc now bleeding in the water coughed up his death rattle in sync.

But all actions have a reaction, and to fire from a hole was to reveal you were in said hole. A tattooed man with a handlebar mustache and the confusing half-strength half-sagginess of middle-age swung his LMG over the top of the bench he hid behind and fired blindly into the hole with a gritted smile. He loved his job.

Someone screamed.

Chapter 6 -

Dan pulled his sopping self out of the water and took the opportunity of distraction to launch another shot over the bench. But now in formation, the mercs were behind cover and ready to return fire.

“Fahkin’ shitlick dick ass!” Dan hissed under his breath calmly.

If only it were easy to obtain hand grenades; you never had hand grenades when you needed hand grenades. This had all been a wildly unsuccessful effort. Dan was reminded of how he hated, HATED, private militaries.

What could he do?

Niam was running in such a manner that it looked as if he were trying to catch his own shoelaces, spending more time doubled over than upright. Oxford shoes weren’t meant for agility.

Even still, with mysterious armed marauders on his trail, anyone could find the will to pick up the pace.

Concrete walls and yellow metal scaffolding flew by, as well as the white serpentine bolted body of the particle collider that once housed his great prize. There were no doors, and no hatches. Once, maybe twice, a foreign device would line the wall: strange terminals.

Footfalls bounced off the walls, his own and his pursuers. The scientist had no knowledge of how far he intended to keep running, it just seemed like running was the right

thing to do when your life was threatened. It was a performance, of sorts. His hubris had caught up to him. Now, he was simply finishing up his role in the final act.

It was penance for the drinking, and penance for the ego; and the fear. It was good this was happening.

Niam's pace slowed down as his legs started to burn within. Maybe it was time he quit trying, he had given as much effort in flight as necessary.

At some point he hadn't realized, perhaps the fall into the dumpster, his glasses had become crooked. He didn't bother correcting them.

Nowhere to go, as he had always felt, and no one to save him, as it should be. Niam simply began walking forward, more out of a sense of obligation than survival instinct. His hands found his pockets once more, including the sample inside.

This was one of those impossible situations. Dan hated impossible situations, because he kept finding himself in them and only ever got out of them through some convoluted series of events he never felt privy to even himself.

But in the moment, they were huge stressors. Terribly tense for the shoulders.

"Двигайтесь вместе! Обойдите его с фланга!" an oily voice barked.

Dan was pulling out shells from all manner of pocket and jamming them into his gun therapeutically. He ejected the previous shell, and it popped into the surface of the rising water before flying back up to the top.

The water was now well-above waist-level now from where Dan was crouching. As the mercs assembled to approach him, they now had to wade forward: making their approach loud, and slow.

Dan was pretty short on ideas. He had a gun, sure, but they had somewhere in the range of five. He wished there were some crazy chemicals sitting out he could take advantage of, but as it turns out, chemists usually put their work away when they're done—even if they had somehow forgotten to build a drain into this room.

Out of desperation, he opened the drawer next to him, and reached inside. He had uncountable moments left; if this didn't yield something good, this might all have been for naught.

Whatever he grabbed, it was some form of glassware. Labs were full of this sort of thing. It was capped, and about the size of his hand. It didn't matter if he knew what it was, he had to take it and treat it as if it was the *deus ex machina*.

He brought it in front of him and flipped the cap off. The clear liquid inside began hissing and bubbling. It made no smell, but that meant nothing at all.

The mercs were about to turn the corner on him, one on each side. There was no way out of this situation.

No way but down. Dan flung the liquid into the sky, then dived beneath the rising water. From beneath the surface, he fired one more shot in the direction where he suspected an aggressor to appear. Pellets met wall and termite-like shrapnel flew out, but

even from within mouthfuls of the tasteless water Dan heard piercing shrieks of agony, drawn out screams.

Heavy weights dropped into the water. Whatever was happening, this was his only chance. Using the corners of counters, he pulled himself along the floor, his black jacket a tangle of seaweed beneath the waves.

An unidentifiable mass clung to the floor in front of him as he passed lab benches. It came included with a human-shaped shell and an assault rifle with a red-hot barrel. Armored hands grasped for the floor in tremors, fighting to stay under the water.

Dan grabbed the rifle and swashed it aside, pushing past to get to the door. Impossible situations always seemed to end up like this, he noted as the water grew hotter and hotter; a ridiculous turn of events.

Once at the door, he had no way of reaching the doorknob without leaving the water and risking himself to whatever mysterious hell lay above its surface. Thankfully, the door had glass built into its frame, and Dan knew of one way to solve most problems.

When the shell ejected, it was caught in a current of water rushing out the new opening in the door. Dan, too, followed it out, crawling over the metal frame of the door and gasping in the open air of the laboratory hallway.

There can't have been *that* much of whatever was in that container; it must've burned itself out. Dan picked himself up as quickly as he could—a slightly difficult task due to a sopping wet leather jacket—and whipped around, ready to fire at anything moving.

He had to rethink this instinct however, as the only things moving were writhing on the floor in pain, crying and groaning. Dan caught a glimpse of one of their faces from under a ballcap: it was soft, raw, and bloody like they'd all been burned alive. They weren't dead, but no one loses their face and stands up to keep shooting.

Chemistry must be the most frightening of the sciences, he concluded to himself.

Dan reentered the room, sloshing through the hot remnants of water to reach the fume hood he had seen Dr. Been climb into only a couple intense minutes ago.

It was littered by a macabre carnival fairground of glass shards, bullet shells, and leaking blood. Dan pinched his forehead and grimaced.

The scientist had not survived the encounter. This operation was a total failure: he hadn't managed to save anyone, nor anything.

He slammed his fist against the hood and hung his head. Nothing would be different had he shown up or not.

Then he trudged out of the room, taking a precariously long step over a bawling balled up body of a human being.

It may be time to simply leave; cut his losses and look for other ways to defy the oppressive regimes that bind the world.

Stopping in front of the staircase like a sulking child, he glanced up at the heavy doors. A bullet casing rolled down from one step to the next. Dan shook his head with the exasperation that came with unfinished business. He couldn't quit yet. There was still one.

But clearly, trying to bring those he rescued to his motorcycle wasn't working. So, he'd just have to bring the motorcycle to them instead. He turned around and headed for the parking lot.

The alley his bike was kept in may have been shut with a padlock, but Dan had a pump-action skeleton key.

Niam couldn't even muster the energy to walk, and he instead leaned against the side of the tunnel with heavy panting. The interlacing metallic mesh of the catwalk beneath him faded in and out of focus. He was too tired to move, too tired to care.

His hand rested on an unfamiliar surface, one with a screen and buttons. Niam glanced over and saw that he was resting on a plastic explosive, recognizable instantly by its distinctive colored wires. His expression soured like someone had just told him they forgot his birthday.

He clasped his hands together and noticed they were sweating, making his nitrile gloves sticky. Not an unreasonable response to realizing you're not more than a foot away from a bomb. One nervous footstep back. He reached backed into his pocket to check on his sample once more like one might check on their kid in the backseat.

Then he took a step forward and bent over to leer at the LCD display. It read blank. Niam sighed in relief. It must not be armed.

The pounding in his ears finally calming down as he at last could rest for a moment, it no longer sounded as if anyone was chasing him. It was perplexing, but he was hardly in the state of mind to think about it critically.

Critically.

Critical.

Critical mass.

Niam knocked on the door of his own skull. He kept falling in holes. All this was about to culminate in a massive boom. *He was sure of it.*

The tunnel rumbled and lights died. Sound caught up to itself and roared like a passing specter. Niam cowered and covered his ears.

The sky tore, or at least pieces of the roof did.

The buzz of life in his head was replaced by a loud ringing. Dazedly, he fell against the bomb that had been in front of him. Covered now in dust and with doubles appearing and disappearing from his vision, he couldn't make out the words on the LCD; but it had not detonated.

Guardian angels must pick favorites.

The dust in the air grew thicker as it had more time to chase Niam down the tunnel. It became increasingly difficult to breathe, and as one does in such cases, Niam fell to the floor face first in an unpleasant bout of asphyxiation.

Dan fancied himself a stoic, a guy who could keep his cool in the most shocking of situations. Even still, he had to look over at the deafening bloom and enlightening fiery plume that followed the explosion in the particle collider tunnel.

Chunks of concrete soared through the air like a suburban volcano.

From the roof, he had a perfect view. He had made his way to the roof, with motorcycle, by walking it through the building and hauling it up the roof access staircase. It wasn't as difficult as it sounds, he only lightly dinged the right rearview on a doorway.

Inside the explosion: that was surely where his scientist was, likely now an unrecognizable pile of charred organic waste. After he went through all that effort to get his bike on the roof and everything.

The tunnel was blasted open along its side, ruptured like someone slit the stomach of a leviathan. In several parts the top had collapsed in, making the spanning structure appear like a great ring of apocalyptic debris.

The eastern side (if a loop could indeed have a "side") was only rubble, where the western side stood much stronger. *Hell*, Dan figured, *maybe someone could've survived in there even during the blast*. But what were the odds?

Dan spun the pump-action around its trigger, opposite hand on his hip, as a force of habit. It was totally fine—the safety was on.

He mounted the bike and revved the engine, charting a path toward the particle collider. There were several feet from the roof and the ground. Quickly, that gap was closed. The suspension would survive.

He was at the entrance of the tunnels now, the roof blown open like a can of soup. Patches of fire roared on in arbitrary spots like a movie. The sun had risen to its fullest point that day and bounced off Dan's glasses.

Then he took off into the tunnels. The catwalks had crumbled, so he rode directly atop the collider itself. Each rivet risked throwing him clean off, but he wouldn't turn around until he found a lab coat or the mangled remains wearing it. Light rolled off his ride as he drove under overhangs of surviving roof structure.

At last, he flew into the most intact section of tunnel. Sunglasses and the headlight cancelled each other out, depicting a consistent blanket of piss-poor lighting. Just a sign was all he was looking for. All he needed to see was a detached arm or tattered bit of cloth and he would know he could turn around. But until then, he just couldn't give the mission up. Not when there was a chance.

Whatever it was he just flew past looked like it could be a chance. Shit. He missed it, and would have to double back. Unfortunately, the top of the particle collider lacked the sort of surface area needed for such a maneuver, and so all he could do was begin decelerating.

When Niam came to, it was with the unique discomfort of a cheek braised against the catwalk, a mixture of his own sweat and drool adhering his skin to the thin metallic bars and leaving an imprint that would redefine his face for the next couple hours. In addition, the arm of his glasses had been damaged on the way down, giving them a looser fit.

But, this all seemed like small potatoes in the face of waking up at all, and with a mostly functioning brain Niam would work to confirm. The first thing that occurred to him was to try to take the integral of something in his head, like he learned in college, to make sure he was still with it.

Then it occurred to him that he wouldn't know how to conjure an integration problem from nowhere to begin with. Also: his arm was numb, something was digging into his side, and his ears were roaring.

Or something was roaring into them. What hound of hell had come to eat him whole?! It settled its unholy gaze onto him with its one bioluminescent eye, like a giant squid passing by in the murky abyss.

"You alive?" Asked a stubbly voice that sounded just like facial hair.

Niam pried himself off the catwalk like peeling an egg off a frying pan.

"That's too metaphysical a question for how I'm feeling right now. You see, I've just passed out, and before that, I've been grappling with some sort of alcohol-induced amnesia. And so, the definition of being alive eludes me right now. I feel somewhere inbetween, I think."

From atop his steed, Dan looked down miserably at the scientist before him, whom looked very much like a cartoon personification of disaster.

"What?"

Niam stumbled about in an attempt to maintain uprightness, then staggered toward Dan.

“Don’t worry about it. You’re a terrorist, right? Good work then. We can wrap this life up nicely—I’ve been running senselessly for too long. Shoot me in the face and let’s be done with it,” the doctor said, gesturing toward the shotgun hanging from the biker’s hip.

Though his sunglasses hid much of it, the expression on Dan’s face featured most prodigiously a significant narrowing of the eyes and an upturned corner of the lip.

“I’m not here to shoot you, I’m here to save you. Save this whole lab. Yeah, well, clearly that plan’s gone to shit-ass. But if I can get you out of here, that’ll be something. I sure hope you’ve got a great memory in that head of yours. The world can’t handle this research dying here.”

“Huh? Not here to shoot me? But you have a gun. They’re *made* for that. I’m sorry, do I know you? Why are you saving me?”

“So forget about great memory, then. I’m going to give you some benefit of the doubt seeing as you’ve just been through an explosion, but for fuck’s sake: pull yourself together! You look like shit and act like it too. Get on the bike.”

He didn’t look much like he knew why, but regardless Niam complied.

“Why are you saving me?” Niam asked again, sounding as if he were staving off sleep.

“Because your research conflicts with the interest of energy elites. And anything that’s bad for them has to be good for us, да? Mix that with personal vendetta, and you have my reason. Unfortunately, according to your old boss, no research is gonna survive. And since the experiment was never actually ran to completion, we don’t even have a product to save.”

Niam clung to Dan like a stuffed animal on the back of the bike, and rested his head on his back. The biker vigilante glanced behind him with unconcealed disgust, but Niam was too close to the realm of sleep to catch it.

"Sure we did," the scientist spoke without opening his eyes, "I've got my modern Prometheus right here."

"I don't know what that means," Dan grunted, trying to rearrange himself such that he wasn't so close to his passenger.

Next step: leave the lab, without detection.

The most Dan could hope for was for the assailants to have left, with them assuming the explosion had finished the job. But it was a small hope, as motorcycles were not silent vehicles.

And come to think of it: even were he to ride back the way he came, he would have to walk his bike back into the building.

"Hey," Dan tapped at his passenger, "hey! Wake up! You work here; is there a quick way out of this tunnel?"

"Why? Where are you taking me?"

"Away, to start. I'd say it's quite likely they know I'm here. If they find out I've got a survivor with me, they'll be on us like flies. For that reason, I'd like to avoid the main road if possible. We just need to get out of this tunnel somehow."

"I think it's important you should know: I've been drinking today—and also I feel nauseous from the constant rotation of the planet Earth as well as my place on it."

"Oh for fuck sake you придурок ебать мусорная обезьяна! Why did you come out wrong from your mother? How do we get out of here?! Simple request!"

"I created something both terrible and beautiful, and cosmically profound today, so you'd better stop yelling at me. I'm a very special person," Niam smiled somnambulantly, "or at least that's what my mom always used to say."

"блять!"

Dan kicked back the stand impatiently and, with only a flick of the wrist, the proud stallion roared forward over the tunnel's remaining catwalks. Sections had fallen, creating holes, declines, and inclines. It was a terrible, bumpy ride that resulted in airtime that would've been better suited for a dirt bike.

Once the top of the tunnel opened into sky, they were in the home stretch. *This nightmare would surely end soon*, Niam thought serendipitously.

Serendipitous as at that moment, something exploded in the near distance. It soared past like a stinging hornet. One with even pedestrian knowledge of American media would be able to recognize it as a bullet. Someone was shooting at them. Maybe a sniper, or a firing squad.

Niam threw his eyes to the sky and smiled expectantly. Dan cursed again, something he made such a habit of it appeared to be single-handedly responsible for the forming of progenitor wrinkles around a scowl.

It wasn't too unlike the first drop of hail, which falls from nowhere and, after a brief moment of poetic pause, hundreds of its siblings come tumbling after. Dan whipped the motorcycle around, nearly toppling the two-wheeled vehicle and whipping Niam around on the back sickeningly.

Going back through the lab was no longer an option. How did they know they were there? There would have to be another way out. Out into the fields. But how could they cross the broken shell of the particle collider tunnel?

Debris and jagged edges rose up like caltrops, even should he find an opening large enough to escape through his tires would never scrape by unharmed.

It was time for that old movie magic again. That old principle that got him out of these impossible situations, just like in the lab earlier. Only this time, he prayed, it wouldn't get his rescuee killed.

He scanned his surroundings quickly like a cat, a trained instinct. All he saw were large scraps of metal, the skeletal remains of a great lab instrument.

Some were flat plates on the floor, others shaped like pikes protruded from the ground some distance away.

Then, Dan spotted it, not more than twenty meters back. A half-pipe splintered off from the top of the collider, leaning atop a sturdy strip of pipe strap. It curved up at its end, bending like a wave.

He revved up his motorcycle, threw his center of balance to the left, and aimed for the pipe.

Niam clung for dear life to Dan, freezing wind attacking each bead of sweat—but the cooling action did little to combat the sickness instilled within him from the intense motion of the speeding bike.

The bike flew up the scrap metal like a ramp. Screeching through the air, stray bullets fired at random warping around the bike miraculously as if reality willed it.

It was utterly unreal the extent to which it mimicked a movie scene. Had Niam not just invented superheavy antimatter earlier that month, he wouldn't have believed it.

A weighty thud when the motorcycle landed atop the last rooved segment standing of the large particle collider tunnel.

To be clear, this is a giant concrete loop trailing for miles behind the laboratory, the majority of which crumbled due to the explosion of planted bombs. This remaining concrete, where one bomb failed to detonate, now had a motorcycle atop it. It had no cover. It was an easier shot to him then now than when they were on the ground.

Dan stared straight into the sun, feeling its omnipotent rays scarring his face. He was wearing sunglasses. It was okay.

Niam gazed into the melting form of the concrete speeding beneath him, and it all became one dreary shape like a brush stroke. It made him feel very, very ill.

Fires still roared on all around, having spread into the dry grass surrounding the great instrument. It was getting absurdly hot, too hot for a leather jacket. Too hot for a lab coat. Too hot for a drunken man being stirred around on a motorized vehicle.

With a nauseating stewing, Niam felt the initial dry heaves of a rising torrential deluge in the recesses of his stomach. He hadn't eaten today. *It* would be acidic and painful; *it* being the great upheaval.

The great upheaval was upon him. It had been building, coalescing, forming, spiraling, making a pooling vortex falling down the garbage disposal, a poisoning of the body of great cosmic extent, the poisoning of his soul would come out with it, he would lose a piece of himself today—

Hyack!

If only it were that short. Instead, a tepid stream of acrid orange-brown upchuck trailed behind the bike like a hole in the oil tank. The ontological fascination with throwing up is that time becomes null, you surrender to oblivion for an indecipherable amount of time, existentially alone in the world. It could be a second, it could be many. It was irrelevant. All that the mind could focus on was the stream of guttural life leaving the body. Out with the bad, in with the good.

Dan glanced over his shoulder at the sorry sight behind him. This had to be the most miserable, shriveled scientist he had ever seen—a powerful claim given the already often miserable and shriveled state scientists typically took on.

Let us not forget that bullets were still flying past. Fire, vomit, and bullets. Fun on a weekend, terrible on a Tuesday.

Yes, look now on the circumstances and grasp them in their entirety:

Niam Wrecker, the ignominious doctor of chemistry, discoverer of the impossible, trailing puke behind him and accepting death. The last of the researchers standing.

The mysterious vigilante Dan, evading death against all odds but unable to save anything with him.

Fires growing larger, shots from distant aggressors on the lab rooftop. The wind and sky were slowly being consumed by smoke. If Niam could see it all from above, and he often felt like he could, he'd be overpowered by its impossibility.

Impossibility. Impossibility? What was impossibility? He had wondered his entire life. Stirred from the oblivion of a stomach purge, Niam began reflecting on his childhood as a bullet singed a stray hair off his head.

"I want to move water with my mind," Niam told his mother. She would have corrected him, telling him people simply can do no such thing.

Dan didn't even bother turning around to glare at the scientist. He had to focus so he could perform the maneuver he saw in his head.

"I wish I could move your mind out of your head and freeze it in water," he mumbled like an insult. He wasn't too concerned with making it make sense, given the circumstances.

A path was dawning in the emerging fields. One without fire, which was a large part of what made it such a tempting choice for Dan.

"We're going to jump," he yelled back at his drunken co-pilot.

"Ulp."

Dan prepared to pull up on the bike. He wasn't necessarily sure this would actually help with the jump whatsoever; that would require an absurd amount of strength. But it did help him feel a lot more confident.

Niam tapped Dan on the shoulder. "I am going to throw up again," he explained calmly.

The motorcycle followed the curve of the cylindrical top of the concrete tunnel softly and favored toward the ground at a sharp angle, front tire poised to meet the earth. Given the speed and direction (that's velocity!) of the wheel, once the bike made contact with the ground it would surely topple fully head-over and break the necks of both riders.

A bullet struck the motorcycle's fuel tank in mid-air, cutting right through the top. If so much of the gas hadn't already been exhausted that day, the heat from the bullet may well have ignited the odorous mix of hydrocarbons and combusted. Or as Dan would put it: the tank would have "fucking exploded".

As promised, Niam threw up again. It made an arc through the air.

The front tire plodded into a sandy patch of dirt and caught. For an uncountable number of horrible moments, the motorcycle sat suspended in air, up-and-down on its nose like a fixture of the earth—or the Earth. Dan had stopped revving, pulled on the brake, and leaned back as fast as he could.

This lean-back slammed Niam in the face, momentarily distracting from the urge to hurl once more. These urges came in waves, so it was merely a delaying of the inevitable. If a man had to puke, he surely would.

It was like riding a metallic bronco, the forces of physics trying their damndest to fling the pair off the bike as punishment for their misbegotten plan. It took nothing short of incredible thigh strength to keep Dan mounted. Niam had no such thing, and as a result of a back to the nose, had just flung his arms up in the air and reeled backwards.

With the bike perpendicular to the ground, Niam fell on top of Dan. All this occurred in a matter of moments.

Far away, a mercenary viewed the scene with an 8.0x Magnification scope, made by a Russian producer that doesn't exist anymore.

His name was Pekov.

Pekov licked his dry lips and simply stared at the absurd spectacle. He had stopped firing just to watch. With a quick glance, he looked to the right to see his compatriot doing the same.

Operations were usually in-and-out blackout jobs. If there was resistance, you shot at it. Things didn't usually survive being shot. If they did, you'd shoot again. This was only Pekov's second mission running with the Dyavola PMC unit. The first one had been absolutely nothing like this.

"Стрелять!" cried his raspy superior.

Pekov obeyed and pulled the trigger, yet found his magazine dry. That's why he had stopped firing in the first place; he had forgotten. His boss came up from behind and kicked him in the ass, calling him an imbecile.

The bike now was starting to teeter with the rear wheel to the earth rather than in the sky—a safe recovery. Parallel with the world once more. A straight tangent line into the cosmos.

Through some form of miracle Niam ended up more or less back on the seat properly, clinging to his rescuer.

With gritted teeth, Dan revved the motorcycle forward. This day would be over soon, he just had to tell himself that. This rotten, violent day would go down as one of the most important in history.

Hopes were rising, the sun was setting, and once it got to speed the motorcycle cruised across the peaty earth.

The warmth on Niam's face, he thought, must be coming from booze. But no, it was heat from the rapidly rising fires all around.

The inferno approached. Explosions tended to make fires, and dry brush tended to propagate them. The motorcycle roared on.

Their assailants had stopped firing—they were no longer visible on the roof of the lab in the distance. Now in the clear, all Dan had to do was get Niam somewhere safe. He could replicate the research. This wasn't a bust.

It wasn't much longer of driving when Dan realized it would not be that simple. No, of course it wouldn't be, this whole day had been one absurd blockade after another. The

fires grew larger, more voracious, more intent on leaving nothing but ash in the wake of the Windslow field.

It spread faster than the motorcycle could in the distance. The horizon, once painted with blue skies, now bore a warmer palette: that of orange and red streaks dripping down the sky.

“We can’t keep going this way, we’re going to have to turn around,” Dan shouted back at Niam through the wind.

“Blegh,” Niam replied.

Cut off by fire, the bike curved hard to the left, into hillier terrain. The tire tore up grass and peat, it was getting harder to control the directory of the bike. The ride was getting shakier.

“I can’t control this musor shit!” Dan shouted back at Niam, trying to keep his eyes on the path ahead of them.

“Fuuuuuck,” Niam said in response, clutching his stomach.

There was a clearing up ahead. If they could just reach the clearing, there would surely be another path and they could quit the off-roading.

The bike hit the upper end of a concrete barricade half-submerged in the mud and sent the duo careening off its mount and into the wet ground ahead, narrowly avoiding the various bits of detritus and junk scattered about.

Someone must've been using this place as a private dumping ground to avoid paying for a permit. Abject scrap metal, oil drums; all the makings of an idyllic oxidizing junkyard.

The mud was soft enough to cushion the blow of a human body (or two) crashing into it, but it still found ways to leave its marks in long brown streaks across Niam's freshly cleaned labcoat. It similarly caked Dan's leather jacket and left a sprouting concave of earth atop the knees of his black jeans.

The collision with the ground, though gentle enough not to break any bones, was not as kind to apparatuses of facial apparel and medical assistance—raising his head from off the cold, goopy ground, the doctor found his perspective of the world filtered through two off-kilter lenses that were undergoing their own journey to stay on.

Dan's sunglasses were indestructible. He wasn't worried about the mud.

"Fuckin' fuckhole, stupid fucking hell of fuck!" he shouted, picking himself up from the ground.

"It's okay," Niam whispered calmly, taking a moment to spit some dirt out, "at least we're not getting shot at anymore."

He spoke as if he had realized he was in a dream: totally detached from the outcome of all things.

"Well I'm not happy. This jacket is going to be a *fuck* to wash."

"A bitch," Niam corrected. "A bitch to wash."

"I don't care! Let's just grab the bike, and—"

But when he turned to the motorcycle, he saw that it had fallen to its side. Trickling from the hole that had been shot through the oil tank was a black, ichorous blood.

“Crude hydrocarbon mixture...” Niam whispered to himself with a smile, before being interrupted by a shove to the back.

“Don’t just stand there, idiot! Pick it up! Go, go!” Dan hissed as he rushed for the bike. Niam didn’t move, returning right to how he was standing before the shove.

Desperately, Dan worked to get the motorcycle upright once more—then suddenly froze.

The air, once mute of all but the distant crackle of fire, was now invaded by a deep growing reverberation. The roar of engines, moving together like a herd.

“Son of fucking bitch! They don’t give up!”

He dropped the motorcycle and it landed back on its side in the seeping mud.

Then, he rushed to Niam and grabbed him by the shoulders, shaking him like an uncooperative vending machine, shouting at him loud enough that spit flew in his face.

“Where are you! Really, tell me, where are you?!”

Niam could only narrow his eyes to slits and raise his brow. He was struggling to remain present enough to even notice the yelling.

“I’m right here, aren’t I?”

“Clearly not! Clearly fucking not! Do you understand what’s been happening? Do you understand what’s at stake? I’m trying to save your life here, all I ask is you act like you want to be saved!”

“Like I want to—I don’t know, why would I? What’s it matter? I’m a mess, I don’t fit in, my coworkers are all dead, my life’s work is destroyed.

“I was running away more out of obligation than desire, like I had a role to play; now my tank is running low. I’m tired. I’m ready to die like my colleagues. I always knew my life would end in catastrophe.”

Niam was slowly coming back to the present as he talked through his feelings, but that didn’t mean he liked it.

“What’s it matter? What’s it matter?! Idiot! Stupid fucking idiot! Right now, you’re the only man on Earth who knows what you know. You’re the only man on Earth with this knowledge, knowledge so dangerous that mercenaries have been hired to kill you.

“And if someone would pay to have it erased, that means it’s something that’s good for humanity. I don’t like that that’s how it works, but that’s how it works. Are you following me?

“You’re all that remains of something that could better lives, that could help the planet, that could oppose tyranny. You’ve come this far, and now you’ll just throw it away? You’ll just give up? I *loathe* that it’s you whose left, and not that older lady I met in the cafeteria. She had a head on her shoulders and a will.”

Niam didn't respond right away. He just ran over the surfaces of the sample in his pocket repeatedly, anxiously.

"The only man on Earth whom... with the knowledge that..."

Something very small and quiet began growing inside him. Or maybe it wasn't growing yet, a seed was only planted; but Niam took no notice of it. Instead, something obvious came around and hit him like a boomerang.

"Hey, by the way, I have this," he said as he pulled the sample he'd been carrying around out and presented it to Dan.

Dan didn't look down at it right away, he was still breathing heavily after shouting at the scientist and expecting a response.

When he did at last look down at the outstretched hand, at the weird little colorless crystal wrapped in film, he was not at all sure just what it was he was looking at.

Actually, it'd be more accurate to say he didn't have a single clue. He raced to find some sort of explanation, just any word that could satisfy its dimensions, but all he could think of was 'thing'.

"What the fuck is it?" he asked plainly.

"My life's value," Dr. Wrecker replied. "The reason why it matters. That is, the reason why I can't die yet."

"That... *thing*? That little *thing*? Looks like a rolled cigarette. *This* is your value?"

"I took it from the collider. It's mine. I made it." Niam raised the sample to the sky, a weird sort of look coming over his face. "You said it yourself, after all. This could better everyone's lives."

Though obscured by his sunglasses, Dan's eyes bulged from his skull.

"You took it—then *that*? That's what I think it is? You've had it this whole time?!"

"Let's go," Niam said suddenly, "all of the sudden I feel like I want to live. Moreso than I've felt for the past decade."

"Finally—finally you're talking sense! Are you listening to me now? I've got a contact; there's a safehouse, and a place we can take that sample."

The world fell to an ear-splitting silence. The engines had stopped.

"You want to live, right?" Dan asked suddenly.

"Much to my own surprise."

"Then get behind something!" He hissed, diving behind a piece of abject scrap metal.

Looking like he just woke up for his very first day on Earth, Niam spun around wildly looking for something to hide behind. He ultimately scrambled to an oil drum and threw his back up against it.

And now, we arrive at a familiar scene. The theoretical yield has come to truth, a product synthesized from the boiling political tensions of a world at a loss for energy and in a vie for control—and not the scientific method kind.

Though it was many pages ago, it should be recalled the situation the subjects of this story have found themselves in. If not, return to the beginning of the experiment and review the reaction.

There is a grenade placed at the foot of a puking doctor. A jacketed man shouts obscenities for his life. The progression of society lay in the senseless judgment of a fragmentation bomb.

Surely there was some fickle chemistry that would save them. A spark that misses, a moisture that keeps the powder from igniting, a strange vent of an inert gas enshrouding it; surely anything. Right?

Flailing desperately, Niam threw something at the grenade. It was a round metal half-circle of decent make but oxidized in the open air, filled with holes like the sky had opened up and rained needles on it: it was a colander. It fell over the top of the grenade and encased it like the dome that it was.

Dan hardly had time to laugh grimly. "That's not gonna— are you stu—"

A deafening explosion ate all surrounding sound like a voracious and roaring monster of Greek myth, and had their hearing not been totally ripped away from them in that moment the pair would've also been able to hear the high-pitched squealing of the colander rocketing miles into the sky.

Something important to note about fragmentation grenades is that they fragment. Their eggshell cracks and sends plastic knives spinning out at a hundred angles. Upon

detonation, most of this shrapnel ended up in the thick rusting hide of the colander—but tiny pieces managed to make it through the holes.

Flung backward from the force of the explosion (even if miraculously and dubiously reached by none of the combustion), Dan and Niam had no time to react or cover their eyes in response to anything. Junk flew loose, mud erupted like a geyser.

A dull yet suffocating pain that spread: Niam's back made rather painful and direct lumbar contact with the oil drum he had been using as cover. The only reason he could keep his grip on his pistol was because it was all he had to focus on. He hadn't realized how tight he'd been holding it until the pain in his back forced his other muscles to relax.

Vision became stars. White strings dances like iridescent streamers. His ears screamed, they screamed! Screamed like the hiss of a leaking vacuum!

Then he was back, Dan shaking him back into place of his corporeal form.

"Quit dying, you bag of fuck! I thought you recovered that 'will of life' or what have you in English!"

"My body is a chemical reaction whose major product is suffering!"

Dan said nothing. He had run out of processing power to lend any to handling the doctor's penchant for existentialism.

"We can't keep doing this," Niam continued, "how long until this day ends? It's been an eternity of running!"

“You ask an insufferable number of questions. I will tell you just this for now: sometimes, you have to do things you weren’t ready for. You realize you actually were ready for them all along; that’s a sign post on that ‘road to self-discovery’. I’ve made a couple treks on it myself. Now for love of fuck, today you live!”

Niam stirred, surprised by how awake he suddenly felt.